Dig Two Graves

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38733021.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Double Trouble & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Bow (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), "Kyle" | Horned Crimson Waste Goon (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Moral Dilemmas, Revenge, Does Finn Kill Catra? I Don't Want to Know, Double Trouble is a Jerk, Double Trouble Loves Drama, Consequences, Guilt, Survivor Guilt, Also guilt because you killed your adopted child's biological parents when you were a teenager, Fluff and Angst, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Therapy Cat Melog (She-Ra), Implied/Referenced Character Death

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English

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Part 2 of The Lizard

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by tjsthelifeofice

Summary

Catra and Adora decide to settle down, have a nice, normal, civilian life with fake names to protect their identities.

They, now called Cat and Addie, adopt a child named Finn.

Finn doesn't know their identities.

After learning that their biological family was killed by the Horde, Finn sets out to find and kill Catra, unaware that they are chasing down their adoptive mother.

Notes

My brain: So how did Finn happen?

Me: Doesn't matter.

My brain: I bet they're an orphan. But what happened to their biological family?

Me: Don't do this.

My Brain: A fin is a fish part, and this show is really on the nose with names, so...

Me: Please no.

My Brain: Finn is from Salineas and Catra killed their biological parents during the war.

Me: Why. Why do you do this.

My Brain: And now you must write a fanfic about it!

Me: And now I must write a fanfic about it.

A House on the Sand

"Finn! Wake up! It's time to get ready for school!" Finn woke up. Ugh. School. "C'mon, I made pankaces! I *know* they're your favorite! It's… it's a work in progress, but I'm learning!" There was the smell of fire and brimstone.
"Addie, there's a reason my *other* mom does most of the cooking around here." Finn said, yawning and shuffling into the kitchen.

"And that's why there are so many stray furs in our food. So if I don't learn to cook, we'll all be coughing up hairballs forever."

"Cat and I *already* cough up hairballs, *mother.* And why does *she* get to sleep in? "

"Because *she* doesn't have school today."

"But it's so *boring.* All we're doing is studying that Horde war stuff. You two already lived through that, you could probably tell us everything I need to know about it."

"Yeah but Cat has too many bad memories and I can't explain everything in a way that makes sense."

"Whatever, Addie. Pure of heart, dumb of ass, we get it." Finn said.

"Swear Jar." Cat said from her spot on the couch.

"MOM! I *know* you're awake. Now take over the griddle before your wife burns down the whole entire house!"

"I'm not awake."

"You're talking."

"I'm talking in my sleep. Deal with it."

"Smell the air." Cat started sniffing.

“OH HOLY CANNOLI! Babe, no offense, but what the hel-” Cat glanced at Finn. “-HECK did you put in those pancakes?”

“Well pancakes are just cakes, but in a pan, right? So I poured the cake mix into the pan and-”

“No that’s not how you make pancakes. If you absolutely *need* to learn how to cook we can get Uncle Wrongie to give you lessons.”

“Well why don’t *you* teach me?”

“I’d love to, but we’d wind up getting *distracted.* ”

“Ew! Moms! Get a room!”

“Sorry sweetie. We got a little carried away. Now hurry up and get ready for school before we do it again.” Addie said

“Using our ultimate true love for each other as a weapon against our own child!?” Cat gasped. “Oh, I *am* a bad influence on you…”

“And I will be forever in your debt.”

“I’m gonna make some cereal, but then I’m going immediately to school. You can canoodle or whatever when I’m gone.”

“Don’t forget to brush your teeth!” Addie called.

“Not to mention my eyes and ears, but sure.” Finn cleaned himself up and left the house. “Ugh. So tired. I do *not* have the energy for this.” Fin complained to himself. “Wish I didn’t have to go to school.”

“Your wish is my command!” Said a pink… thing.

“What are you?” Asked Finn, taking in the weird wings, pink everything, and general frilliness of this newcomer.

“Why, I’m Flutterina of course! Your fairy godparent!”

“Fairies aren’t real, though.” Finn said incredulously.

"No? Ehe, we have a real grown-up here, folks! *Aren't you a clever one."* Flutterina said sarcastically. "Well, if you're too *mature* for a little fantasy, I suppose I'm just your *regular* godparent. Who the heck gets to decide what's real, anyway? Aliens, spaceships, magic, She-Ra, special rocks that enable the monarchy… well, you're right about one thing. I'm *not* a real fairy. Kudos to you-dos, I guess. Fairy Godparent just happens to be the closest descriptor to what I am, so."

"So why are you here? And how do I know I can trust you?"

"I'm here because your mother lost a bet she probably forgot about by now, and you can trust me… huh. You know, I can't really think of a good reason why you should trust me. But I can grant that wish, if you want.

"What wish?"

"The thing you just wished for, silly! *You* wished you didn't have to go to school, and I can make that happen! No monkey's paw junk, no *For Want of a Nail* nonsense. Just an honest favor for my godchild!(That's you, Finn.)"

"So how can you help me?"

"Like so: Voila!" Flutterina turned a dark green color, and they stretched and shrunk and twisted into… something else. Color returned. Finn was suddenly looking at their exact duplicate. "Cool trick, right? You can spend the day doing whatever kids do without parents and teachers and other tyrants saying you can't, and I tell you what you missed *after* school. In my experience, they spend *too long* teaching kids like you *too little.* So what do you say, kitten?"

"Woah."

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“Alright, Finn’s gone. We can use our real names now.” Adora said. Catra sighed.

“Feels a little bad though, doesn’t it? Don’t get me wrong, it’s nice to just relax now, and this whole ‘secret identity’ game is really fun, but it doesn’t feel right to keep Finn in the dark.”

“Yeah, I know. We didn’t tell them at first because we wanted them to like us for who we are instead of just because we’re important. But then we didn’t want to tell them because we were worried that they’d tell other people. And then we just never told them. But at the same time, telling them about this feels… like burning a bridge. If we do it, we can’t take it back, and then nothing will be the same.”

“I feel the same way. I want to come clean, like I said, but I’m too scared. If they find out who I am… If they learn about what I did, I don’t- I don’t think… What if they hate me? What if they’re scared?”

“They won’t hate you. They might be scared at first, but they love you. Hey, look at me. Glimmer used to hate you, remember? But then you got to know each other, and I think she’s *still* crushing on you.” Catra snorted.

“She’s got arrow boy though, and I’ve got you, so that’s never gonna happen.”

“That’s not the point. What about Perfuma and Frosta? They started out giving you the stink eye and walloping you with ice fists respectively. Now they charge-tackle you into a hug whenever you’re in the same room.”

“My bones.”

“POINT IS. People don’t stay mad after you. Not if they get to know you.”

“Yeah, well, other people don’t have teen angst. They’re gonna hate me anyway when they go through that phase we read about. Except this time, it’ll be justified.”

“Don’t say that! You’re the best mom on Etheria! And the whole ‘teen angst’ thing was about rebelliousness. We’ll be lucky if they don’t raze cities in your name.”

“Adora, I know you’re trying to make me feel better, but please don’t joke about that right now.”

“Sorry.”

“Yeah. Usually I’d be okay joking about that, but… I’m still worried about something going wrong, ya know?”

“You know, I could call up ‘Auntie Flowers’ or ‘Auntie Linda,’ you know how good they are with feelings and stuff.”

“Scorpia has a lot on her plate right now, but I guess talking to Perfuma might help. Nobody can read minds quite like her. Nobody except- Nevermind, you wouldn’t get the reference.”

“I’ll get her here. Until then, do you want anything? Coffee? Tea?”

“Adora, you can’t use anything remotely warm without starting a fire. …Get me some applesauce with cinnamon. Please?”

“As you wish!” Said Adora cheerfully.

“I should have *never* shown you that movie.” They spent the day cuddling and relaxing, and when Perfuma arrived, Catra was able to make sense of a lot of stuff. When all was said and done, everyone felt better. All in all, it was a good day.

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Finn was spending some time under a shady tree by a brook. They skipped some stones, took a nap, ate their packed lunch when they were hungry *instead* of when some bell said they could, played some games on their tech pad… It was a good day. Then Flutterina appeared.

"Hellllll-LO! How has your day been?"

"It's been good. Very relaxing, thanks."

"Hey, you remember what our deal was, right? I have to tell you what you missed. If you suddenly forget what you learned, people are going to be suspicious."

"I guess that makes sense. I wish it didn't have to be so boring, though."

"Your wish is my command, kitten. Why settle for a boring lecture when you could have a *live reenactment!"*

"You can do that?"

"Of course!" Flutterina shifted into Horde Prime. "It all started with this guy! …But the lesson didn't even mention me." Horde Prime's face pouted hilariously, before contorting into a look of outrage as it became Hordak's Face "It didn't even think *I* was more important to be something other than a FOOTNOTE! It called *me* the 'figurehead leader' of the Red Horde. Do I look like a *FIGUREHEAD* to you?" Finn giggled. "Of course, we all know who the *real* power behind the throne was…" Double Trouble shifted into a new shape, but didn't add detail or color. "Force Captain Catra. Under *my* management, the Horde *actually* became competent. Thousands of villages and towns and cities and *whole kingdoms* crushed under my heel! Firs Thaymoor, then Dryl, then Salineas, then the rest of the universe! And if someone gets in my way…" They shifted into a bunch of different shapes, mimicking terrified screaming. Humans, sea elves, lizardfolk, and a lot of magicats, lingering on one that looked a lot like Finn. Flutterina's

shape and color returned to the usual weird pink. "Oh no. I just had a horrible thought."

"What is it, Flutterina."

"Oh, I'm not sure I should tell you. It would only get you upset."

"... I *wish* you would tell me what you just thought."

"Guess I have no choice, then. Your moms… you're adopted, right?"

"Yeah, I remember. After the Horde lost the war, the cadet program was turned into an orphanage or something, by princesses Scorpia and Perfuma. Then Addie and Cat showed up and took me in."

"Finn… those 'cadet programs' recruited from kids who'd been orphaned by the Horde. You don't think…"

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Finn walked in.

"Oh! Hi sweetie, your Aunt Flowers just dropped in for a visit. Did you wanna say hi?" Addie asked. Then she took in Finn's expression. "Finn? What's wrong?"

"A lot, actually. I need to talk to you and Cat for a moment. Alone. This feels… important."

"Alright. Then I will take my leave. Tell me if Catr-CAT. Tell me if *Cat* needs anything else." Aunt Flowers said.

"Will do, Ma'am. Say hi to Aunt Linda for us!"
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"She'll be happy to hear it!" Aunt Flowers left, waving a friendly goodbye. Finn and Addie went to the living room, where Cat was waiting for them.

"Honey? Are you up for more emotional conversation? Something happened to Finn." Cat sat straight up from where she had been curled on the couch, looking at Finn and taking them in.

"You've been crying. But now you look like you've made… the kind of decision I've always wound up regretting when it's too late. What's on your mind, kid?"

"Moms… you two have taken care of me for a long time. But what I learned today had me thinking. About… things." Tense silence.

"What kind of things?" Cat asked.

"Like, what happened to my biological parents. I *know* you got me from the ex-Horde orphanage. So there's no *good* answer for this. …They died. The Horde killed them. So I've decided to do something about it." Deep breath in. "I'm going to find Catra. I'm going to find the woman who killed my parents… and I'm going to kill her." They looked at their moms. Addie looked terrified. Cat… it was hard to read her expression. Not quite fear, but not quite not-fear either.

"NOT YET! *Not. Yet.* …Not yet." Cat took a deep breath to regain her composure. "... Not until summer break. That will let you finish up this years worth of education and give me time to prepare… for your trip. Okay?" Cat smiled.

"WHAT! Cat, we are *not* letting Finn do this!"

"So what am I supposed to do then? Just let her get away with it?" Finn asked.

"Yes! That's *exactly* what you're supposed to do! Catra, she's… Cat, help me out here!" Cat didn't help her out. "Finn, listen to me. You *can't* kill Catra, okay? I mean, even if you could find

where she's been this whole time, it would be really dangerous! If you *do* find her, what are you going to do?"

"Use these." They said, unsheathing their claws nonchalantly.

"But what if you don't find her? Or what if you find her and she's already dead! Or she doesn't deserve to die? Or- I don't know! Please, Finn, I don't want you to do this. Please don't go. …Stay."

"Stay? And do what? Stay here and play house with the two of you forever?" Finn clapped their hands over their mouth. "I- I'm sorry. I don't know where that came from, it just slipped out-"

"It's okay." Cat said. "I get it. We all say and do things we regret in the heat of the moment. Come here." Finn walked up and Cat hugged them. "Just stay until summer break, okay? It'll give us all some time to get ready. Promise?"

"... Promise."

"Are you seriously okay with this? With Finn just going out and-"

"I'm not okay with it. But I don't think I can stop them, can I?" Cat asked. Finn shook their head, which was still buried in Cat's shoulder. "...Just like I thought. They're gonna try to do this whether we want them to or not. But if we try to stop them, they'll be doing it all without us looking after them to keep them safe."

"I know, but isn't there something we can do or say or-"

"Probably not. Listen, I'm a little tired. You and I can discuss this tomorrow, while Finn's at school. Hey, I know what'll cheer us up! We'll all just cuddle together on the couch. We can tell stories about our own adventures, and how we got together! How does that sound?" Finn and Addie both nodded. "Alright, where do I begin…"

Story Time

Chapter Summary

> Cat and Addie tell Finn about their history, with names changed to protect the innocent (and the guilty).

"Hm. At the beginning, of course! It all starts in the Horde. I forget how old I was, but I'd hidden in a box to avoid being caught stealing ration bars, but then that box got delivered to the other side of the Fright Zone!"

"Were you scared?" Finn asked.

"Obviously not. Not anymore than I usually was, anyway. The Horde was always a dangerous place to be in. Being moved across the planet in a cardboard box wasn't any more scary than, say, being executed or banished, both things that could have happened to me if I got caught doing any of the things that made the Fright Zone tolerable. It was a bit of a relief, actually. Until I realized *who* I'd been shipped to."

"What do you mean?"

"The Horde's second in command at the time. She was a ruthless tyrant who would kill anyone who got in her way."

"Catra…"

"No, not Catra." Said Cat with a laugh. "Catra was just a little kid back then. No, the Horde's second-in-command at the time was Shadow Weaver. I knew that if she found me, I was good as dead. So I was scared *then.* Now, Shadow Weaver was a witch, you see. She had magic. If she thought there was an intruder, if she knew I was there… she could just look into her weird cauldron thing and see exactly where I was. So I didn't want her to find me. But here's the thing about emotions, especially strong ones like fear. They don't like to be hidden. It's the reason people laugh while playing hide and seek. So before I knew it, I was crying like a

baby. Ugly crying, tears streaming down my face, all the while trying *not* to make any noise and failing miserably. Then I heard footsteps."

"Was it the witch?"

"Well, I certainly *thought* it was. So I tried even harder to hide my crying, but of course I was even *more* scared than before, because I was so certain that this was curtains for me. And then the box opened, and it was Addie! She offered her hand to me and said something stupid like, 'hey you're fluffy, do you want to be my friend?' and then we were friends." Cat reached for Addie's hand. Addie returned the gesture. "Best friends. And, as luck would have it, Addie was Shadow Weaver's favorite, so the Witch couldn't kill me while I was still friends with her. So we grew up together, and you know, it wasn't all that bad! Sure, we were being trained to subjugate reality to the whims of a corrupt tyrant from outer space, and sure, our caretaker was… 'strict,' but we had each other, and that's what mattered."

"I don't understand though. I thought that Addie worked for the Rebellion?" Finn asked, puzzled.

"I'm getting to that. That part of the story… it's bittersweet, I guess. Addie was going to be promoted to Force Captain. That's a big deal, by the way. Force captains were the highest official rank in the Horde, short of second-in-command. But Shadow Weaver wanted her separated from the rest of the cadets she was raised with. She wanted her separated from *me.* And I guess it's selfish to think of it that way, but that's how I thought of it. So she decided to use her new authority as Force Captain to pull one last chaotic stunt with me. That's when it all went to hell."

"What happened?"

"If I didn't make it clear, it all went to hell. But ultimately, it's what needed to happen." Addie held Cat's hand tighter.

"Can I tell this part?" She asked.

"Go for it."

"I sort of found something cool in the woods, so I decided to sneak out and find it again. Cat covered for me while I got another Horde skiff and made a beeline for the Whispering Woods. There, I found it. First One's tech, though I didn't recognize it at the time. I also ran into your aunt Sparkle, uncle Arrow, and that pen-pal of hers for the first time. She screamed and hit me, and your uncle Bow tied me up. And while I was tied up, I saw a bunch of Horde soldiers stampede an innocent village, so I… yeah, I escaped, but I decided to stick with the Rebellion. The next time I saw Cat… " She trailed off.

"Yeah, I said some things I regret. *Did* some things I regret. I was *pissed.* Addie was supposed to be my best friend, right? But then she just left, and she made new friends, and I felt like garbage. *Very, very, angry* garbage. And, I mean, I get it now. The Horde *sucked,* and it was trying to take over the world so we could all be brainwashed by some space alien with four creepy green eyes, so yeah. Addie was in the right. And it's not like she didn't try to reach out to me. She did, at every opportunity. If I was trying to kill her and the momentum of an attack sent me off a cliff, she'd catch me. And then I'd throw her off that same cliff." Finn laughed. "Yeah, it *is* kinda funny, isn't it?"

"So how did you finally make up?"

"It was after the Green Horde finally showed up. An intergalactic war really makes you reevaluate your priorities. And I sort of realized that Addie was on top. So I helped break aunt Sparkle out of space jail and got chipped for my trouble. Then Addie showed up and hit the back of my neck so hard the chip stopped working. That's why Prime started making the chips stronger, but I digress."

"Okay, so you became friends again after that?"

"Well, yeah, but at first I was mad because she didn't kill me or something? I don't really know, I was sort of out of it. But then things went… not quite back to normal. Things still sucked, and

there was too much bad blood between us to just call it water under the bridge, but you know what? She still made the effort to build a bigger bridge, to reach out to me, even when I wanted to drown in the flood of my own misdeeds."

"Mom, you lost me."

"I thought it was sweet…"

"Whatever. Point is, we wound up together again. It rocked. We got to save each other from bad stuff instead of other people saving us from each other. But we were still too scared to confess."

"I'm gonna be completely honest, I wasn't scared. I just didn't put it all together till the last second. I was all like, "huh. I wonder why I like looking at her so much, and why i feel so nice when she's in the same room as me, and why I want to hug her and stuff. Oh well! Must be my imagination." I've been told that I'm pure of heart, but dumb of-"

"ADDIE! Watch your language!"

"Sorry! Sorry!"

"So what did it take for you to admit your feelings?"

"Well, the world ended. Again. Actually it might have been the *third* time the world ended, come to think of it. I thought, welp, third time's the charm, right? If it sticks, I'm not gonna get another chance. Also Addie was already dying, and I thought I was going to lose any chance with her anyway. So I wanted to at least tell her the truth before everything went to hell again."

"And then I was all like "OH! THAT'S WHAT I'VE BEEN FEELING!" And then we kissed." Addie said.

"And this is sorta why Addie doesn't want you to go after Catra, you know? I mean, in the grand scheme of things, she's not so different from- I'm the same as her. "

“What are you talking about? You’re nothing like her!” Finn exclaimed.

“How would you know? You never met her.”

“Did *you* meet her?” Finn asked.

“I- I- ah jeez. Sort of? It’s complicated. I-”

“So you don’t really know her,” Finn said, giving a sigh of exasperation. “I don’t know her either. But what I do know… I can’t just let it slide, now that I really know about it. She can’t just do what she did and then disappear. She should be dead, or in jail, or *something!* And nobody’s done that. The princesses forgave her so that there could be peace with what was left of the Horde. But *I* haven’t forgiven her, and I don’t have to.”

“That’s the thing though.” Addie said. “You don’t know her. You don’t know why she did what she did, you don’t know anything beyond a few horror stories! You wouldn’t know who she was if she picked you up, sat you down in her lap, and said ‘I’m Catra.”

“I know she killed my parents, and that’s enough.” Finn said. Cat nodded solemnly.

“Revenge. I get it. You want to know where you came from, who you are, and she took that from you. I might not want you to do this, or ultimately thing it’s a good idea, but… it’s your call, kid. I mean, I could throw platitudes and fables about how bad vengeance is at you, but that’d be the pot calling the kettle black. But it’s getting late. You are going to sleep now.” Cat ordered.

“Fine.” Cat, Addie, and Finn collapsed into a puppy pile (kitten pile?) of soft fur and one human thing.

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When Catra was pretty sure that her family was asleep, she opened her eyes. She telepathically called out for Melog. The powerful alien creature, currently in the form of a tame housecat, padded over.

"Are they sleeping?" Catra whispered. Melog nodded. "Good. I have a favor to ask. You probably heard what the kid was talking about, right?"

Your ward wishes you dead.

"Yeah, pretty much. Don't blame 'em."

But they don't know the truth. You could tell them.

"Tell them what? That I'm the despotic warlord they've sworn vengeance against? Best case scenario, they think I'm lying to stop them from doing something I disapprove of. Worst case scenario I wind up dead."

They won't kill you.

"Maybe it will, maybe they won't. Doesn't matter."

*It **does** matter.*

"Either way, everything's changed. There's no mistaking it for anything else. Either way, Finn's got every right to be mad at me. If I were half as good as I pretend to be, I'd probably wake them up and tell them the truth right now. But… I can't. As much as I know it's not real anymore, I just want to keep pretending things are still okay." Catra laughed quietly, careful not to wake anybody up. "Isn't that so *stupid?* I hurt Finn in a way I can't fix or take back. I hurt so many other people besides, and all I can think about is how it effects *my* life."

You have already come to terms with everything else. This is new. Is it any wonder you would focus on that?

"... I shouldn't. If I were really sorry, I wouldn't have ever been okay with *any* of the things I've done."

I do not think you are correct. But I can't persuade you against this. …Why did you call for me, then?

"It was… to ask a favor. When school's over, Finn's going to go out, and they're going to get themself into a lot of trouble. I want you to take care of them, okay? I'll make them take you along, pretend its something sentimental. Make sure they're safe, okay?"

And yet you don't offer to join me. Why?

"I don't think I could stay as close to them as you can without… messing something up. Don't get me wrong, I'm definitely going to be around them the whole way, one step ahead if I can. You can tell me what they intend to do next and then Adora and I can go ahead and make sure they're not getting in over their head." Melog nodded, and crawled up into the puppy (kitten?) pile with everyone else.

Preparations and Procrastinations

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora prepare for Finn to go on their journey

"Finn wants to WHAT!" Glimmer yelled.

"I thought I said it pretty clearly. Did your own shrill voice finally blow out your eardrums?" Catra quipped.

"Oh, maybe! I probably misheard, because it *sounded* like you just said that *Finn.* Wants to *kill you.* "

"Well they don't really know it's me but… pretty much."

"And you're just… OKAY with this."

"Not really, but it doesn't matter."

"It doesn't-!?! Of COURSE it matters!"

"What matters is that Finn doesn't wind up getting killed on his quest thing."

"That's not-! I mean, that's *one* thing that matters! But what about you? Hell, what about Adora!? I mean, her diary said 'dear Catra' instead of 'dear diary' for crying out loud! What's she going to do if…"

"Well what do you want me to do? Kill them first? Because that's a hard no. I'd rather die than hurt them."

"You could tell them the truth!"

"You mean like, "Hey, I've lied to you your whole life and I'm the one who killed your parents?" I can imagine how well *that'd* go over." Catra hesitated. "...I've thought about it. But it feels like- Do

you remember when we were all at Mystacor? Those relaxation springs?”

“Yeah. We were all soaking in the water and you were waiting at the edge. It was obvious you wanted to go in, soak in the minerals and relaxation magic, and chill out for a while, but you stayed on the edge, watching the water like it wanted to kill you.”

“Yeah, pretty much. I knew it would feel really satisfying. I knew it was safe and healthy. But at the same time I just couldn’t. That’s what it’s like now. I wish I could just… jump in.”

“I remember you tried. You almost did but then you flailed and snatched back onto the beach with your claws and pulled yourself back before you even hit the water.”

“...I think I get it. What do you need me to do?”

“Transportation. *We* know exactly where Catra is, but Finn doesn’t. They may wind up all over Etheria. Maybe even offworld, if they find out about our own little ‘roadtrip.’ You can go anywhere where there’s magic, so… Adora and I want to be there to look after Finn, okay? Etheria is a big place, and it’s not safe for one kid to go out exploring on their own.”

“But you *hate* it when I teleport you.”

“It’s worth it.”

“... Fine. I don’t like it, but I’ll do what I can.”

“Good.” Catra hung up the call. “Hey Adora?” She called. Adora had been silent for a while, and Catra was starting to worry.

“Catra? Did you finish calling everyone?” Adora asked from the other room. Her voice sounded…

“Yeah, I’m done. I’m all yours now,” Catra purred, hoping to make her wife feel better.

"...This is all my fault. *I'm* the one who wanted to have a normal life, *I'm* the one who decided to hide away from everyone, *I'm* the one who was selfish enough to-"

"And I'm the one who stomped Salineas to rubble. This *isn't* your fault, Adora."

"Fine then! It's Shadow Weaver! Or Hordak! Or- or Prime! It-"

"Their mistakes aren't my excuses. It's like you said in the portal, I made my choice and now I have to live with it." Adora started crying harder. "Hey! Adora! It's all gonna be okay… come on, pull yourself together, I know you can do it… remember our wedding night? We decided not to do the whole 'sex' thing just then and just cuddle and watch rom-coms on runeflix while eating ice cream?" Adora laughed. Good, this was working.

"Yeah, I remember."

"Well, I've got some. Ice cream, I mean. I *was* saving it for a special occasion, but I really didn't have any specific plans. This seems important enough. What do you say we have a movie night?" Adora laughed again.

"I'd like that." When Finn came back from their meeting with Flutterina, they found their moms askew on the couch with a near-empty bucket of melted ice cream between them and Runeflix playing.

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One week later, when Finn came home from school, Cat tried to approach them.

"Hi honey."
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“Oh. Hey mom.” Cat stood there, nervously fidgeting.

“Did… did you have a good day at school?” Something felt… off.

“Um, yeah.” Finn said. “Mom, is something wrong?”

“Finn, I have a question. It sounds stupid when I think about saying it out loud, but… Hm. I don’t really know how to ask this.”

“What is it?” Finn asked, cocking their head to the side.

“Finn? What would you do if I did… something bad?”

“Something bad? How bad?” Finn asked. And just like that, Cat lost her nerve.

“Like… THIS BAD!” She grabbed a pillow from the couch and tossed it at Finn.

“Ah! No! Pillow ambush, from my own mother!” Finn said, pretending to die dramatically. “Blood… and guts… and death! Blech.” They opened one eye. “Of course you realize, this means war!” They grabbed the pillow and started whacking Cat with it. “PILLOW FIGHT!” Finn was going all out. No mercy, no surrender. But oddly enough, their mother’s heart didn’t seem to be in the battle.

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“I just- I tried. Then they gave me this look and I couldn’t. I- I-” Catra was crying.

“It’s okay. Shh. It’s all going to be okay.” Adora hugged Catra close. It was her turn to be the anchor.
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It was months later when Cat tried again.

"Finn, I have something to tell you." Cat said. "It's very important, and you have to believe me when I tell you."

"What is it?"

"Finn, I- I love you. I love you so much." She hugged Finn tightly.

"Mom? Are you… Crying?"

"I'm sorry. I'm so sorry, Finn."

"You don't need to be sorry for crying. Anty Flowers says it's important to express your emotions sometimes."

"But there's something else I have to tell you. I have to but it-"

"Mom, it's okay. You don't have to tell me anything you don't want to, remember? That's something else Aunt Flowers said, and I think it's important."

"But this is big. I can't just *not* tell you."
"Okay. Then you can tell me later, okay? Wait here." Finn scampered off. "Addie! ADDIE! Cat's crying!" Addie came running to the living room.

"Cat? Are you okay?"

"I… no. I'm not. I guess I'm a little better now that you're here, though."

"Good.

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“Finn?”

“Yes mom?”

“... Thanks. I was really freaking out earlier, and you really helped. …It wasn’t supposed to go like that though. I’m the parent, I’m supposed to take care of you.”

“I mean, you have though, haven’t you? Remember when I was learning how to ride a bicycle, and I fell over on the pavement? I got a cut and started crying, and you *immediately* swooped in to take care of it! And to this day, I still don’t know how to ride a bike.”

“And you never will. Here I thought the Horde was savage. What is the Rebellion thinking, putting children on those death machines?” Catra quipped.

“Mom, it’s not the Rebellion anymore. The Horde’s gone, they don’t have anything to rebel against.”

“Well they always rebel against their own better judgement.”

“Are you ready to talk about that thing now?” Finn asked.

“... No. I want you to know, but at the same time, when I try to say it, it just- nevermind.”

“That’s okay, mom. You can tell me when you’re good and ready.” A thought suddenly came to Finn. “Oh hell no. This had better not be about puberty. I’ve already seen what Horde standard health class is like on the internet.”

“Wha- No! Wait, you don’t seriously mean Hordak’s stupid-”

“It went viral.” Catra started laughing uproariously.

“Oh no!” She said between guffaws. “Oh HELL no!” She started cackling again.

“Honey?” Asked Addie, walking in from the other room. “I haven’t heard you laugh like this since that one time with the deathtrap. Is everything alright?”

“Yes! No! For the love of Etheria-” She took a deep breath in. “Remember that *video* we had to watch when we were thirteen? It went viral.” A strange look crossed Addie’s face.

“ *No.”*

“ *Yes!”* Addie started cackling too. “Oh my god, I have to tell Entrapta!” Everyone forgot about what they were originally talking about and spent the rest of the day watching Etheria’s funniest home videos. All seemed well, until…

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It was the first day of summer break. Finn had packed food, water, clothes, toiletries, money, and miscellaneous necessary garbage. Their mothers had come to see them off.

“So. You’re really gonna do this, huh?” Cat asked

“Yeah. Did you think I was gonna just give up?”

“Nah. Kinda hoped.” Cat said. “Look out for yourself, huh? It’s dangerous to go alone. So take this,” Cat grabbed Melog, the family’s pet cat, off of the floor. “Melog will take care of you. Won’t you, Melog?” Melog stared at Cat and blinked slowly. “Good! Now Finn. There’s one last question. What would you do if Catra turned out to be someone you knew?”

“What? How would that work?”
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“You know, Catra could have been living under a fake name this whole time. Trying to get away from it all, live a normal life. So what would you do if Catra turned out to be someone you knew? Or, thought you knew I guess.”

“What? Mom, the only magicats I really know are you and me. There’s *no* way I could know Catra, even in passing.”

“I know, just. Just humor me on this, okay?” Finn took a deep breath in and thought about it. What *would* they do? They didn’t know. But the look in Cat’s eyes… this was a test. And even if Finn didn’t know what the real answer would be, they knew the right one.

“It wouldn’t matter.” Finn said, trying to act certain. “I have a job to do, and I’ll do it if I can.” Cat grimaced and nodded solemnly.

“Then don’t let me stop you. We called in a favor from Swift Wind. He’ll take you wherever you need to go, and if you don’t-”

“Wait, you knew She-Ra’s horse?”

“Yeah, Addie used to brush his mane. They’re pen-pals now. Point is, he’ll take you where you need to go until you find Catra, then he’ll fly you back. Just… promise to keep in touch, okay?”

“I promise.”

“Good kid.” Cat hesitated for a moment, then hugged Finn tightly. “See you soon, okay?”

“See you soon.”

“Oh! Sorry, hate to cut the hug short. Really I am. But I think Addie has something to say. Can’t hog all the Finn-time, right?” She let go of Finn.

“Hey. Finn?” Addie said, leaning over. “I know what you said about Cat earlier but I have a tip. I encountered Catra a few times during my career, so can I give you a bit of advice.”

"Sure! What do I do if I get in a fight with Catra?"

"Don't. Not unless you're *absolutely sure* about what you're doing. It might backfire otherwise. Okay?"

"Got it. Now, on that note, I've got a flying horse waiting for me. Bye, moms!"

Embark

Chapter Summary

Finn goes to Brightmoon with Melog and Swiftwind, meets Double Trouble again.

"Hey. You're Swift Wind, right?"

"The one and only!" Swift Wind said. "Pleased to hear that my reputation precedes me. And *you* must be Finn! Your mom probably called me 'Spirit' if she mentioned me to you. "

"I wonder why she wouldn't just tell me though?" Finn asked.

"Hm. Well, your mothers are close to some… very important people! Very close! And sometimes, these people don't want to be bugged. So they came up with fake names so people wouldn't bug them when they were visiting your mons, and then the rest of us had to come up with fake names to avoid getting them figured out, and it just got out of hand. Really it's made a bit of a mess for everyone involved but- anyway! That's not why I'm here."

"Right. You're here to help me kill Catra."

"... Um. Yes. Er… about that?" Swiftwind asked. "I'm only the ride, okay? Your moms didn't want you having to travel too far on your own, so they're having me take care of it. I'm *not* going to be taking part in the actual… yeah."

"I get it. You had enough of that in the war, didn't you?"

"I've fought Catra more than I'd care to, I guess." Swift Wind said hesitantly.

"I respect that. Do you want to talk about it?"

"No! Just… tell me where you want to go."

“Brightmoon.”

“Really? Brightmoon? I would have thought you’d want to go to, I dunno, the Crimson Waste? Beast Island? Somewhere that people who want to disappear would go, you know?”

“I get that, but there’s a reason I chose Brightmoon. Catra works as Queen Glimmer’s advisor.”

“Glimmer can teleport though! She can just teleport to wherever Catra lives and hear her advice that way. All her being the queens advisor proves is that-”

“The queen knows where Catra lives. And Catra has to visit Brightmoon eventually, right?”

“I mean, yeah. She has to show up to do her job.”

“Brightmoon it is then.”

“Alright then. Hold on tight!” Finn clung to Swift Wind and Melog held clung to Finn. ”And we´re off!” he sprung up from the dirt and flew a loop-de-loop or two before soaring into the distance.

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”So where to first?” Glimmer asked. Catra tilted her head to the side as though listening to something.

”Melog says they´re headed for Brightmoon.” She said.

”Brightmoon? Really? I´d have thought they´d be trying to figure out where you lived.” Glimmer asked skeptically.

”No, this is actually the smartest thing Finn could do right now,” explained Catra proudly. ”I work as your advisor, everyone knows this. It was on the news as the latest controversial gossip until I
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solved that one problem with tax reform and- nevermind, its not important. What matters is that I visit Brightmoon often to advise you. Finn has a good excuse to visit Brightmoon, because their ´aunt Sparkle´ lives there. It would make sense for them to assume that you (as aunt, not queen) would provide a believable alibi when I (as Catra, not Cat) turned up dead. All they have to do is figure out my schedule and poison my tea or something."

"You look weirdly… happy?" Adora pointed out.

"Of COURSE Im happy! I mean, don't get me wrong I don't like the fact that they're trying to kill me. But they're *good* at it! Baby's first diabolical scheme…" She smiled wistfully. "Almost a shame its not going to work. The only reason it wouldnt is because they wouldn't recognize me as their target, they'd just think I was in Brightmoon to visit you. Which wouldn't technically be wrong. They just don't know that Iḿ Catra and you´re Glimmer. Otherwise, It´s a good plan."

"CATRA!" Adora exclaimed, surprised. "We can encourage this sort of behavior. They cant go rushing in without learning about their targets and any complications before making rash decisions! What if they´re getting led into a trap?"

"They aren't, dummy. We aren't leading them into a trap. Besides, they're a kid! They'll get better at this *eventually.* And didn't you do stuff like that all the time when *you* were in the Rebellion?"

" *Yes,* and I wound up in like, every trap ever? And sometimes there wasn't even a trap and I fell for it anyway? I tried to make a good plan once. It was a disaster. Bow kept dying."

"Yeah, Scorpia told me. Sounded like a riot."

"It kinda was. Point is that Finn should be smarter than me! They don't have the magic sword or the healy glowy stuff or-"

"Yeah, but remember, they're not really in danger right now. They can afford to mess up and make mistakes, because we won't hurt them."

"Well what if someone else does? The Brightmoon Guards don't take prisoners, and it sure as hell isn't because they're running a catch-and-release program." Glimmer pointed out.

"You can just order them to leave Finn alone. You're the queen, you can do that."

"But what about when they're somewhere like Beast Island or the Crimson Waste? There are people there who *won't* go easy on Finn."

"That's why we'll go ahead and kick their butts beforehand to warn them not to mess with our kid, *or else.* Make a show of things. Name drop ourselves. I mean, you're the magic sword lady who ripped out Prime's soul and turned his spaceship into a tree, and I'm… I still have a reputation. Nobody's gonna mess with Finn. They're never unarmed, they have their claws. They're never alone, they have Melog. They're never outgunned, because if they are, we step in. They're gonna be alright."

"...You know what? You're right. We'll be right there for them, even if they don't know it. You've got our disguises ready?"

"I've been working on them for like, weeks. You think I'm just gonna leave them behind at the moment of truth?"

"Let's go then."

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Finn and Flutterina met in Shadow Weaver's old garden when Finn took a detour from the tour of Brightmoon castle.

"Alright, plan of action. Stay with Aunt Sparkles for a while, before and after the assassination so that I'm not suspected as the culprit simply for being at the right place at the right time. Moms
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have already told her about my journey, and she's not gonna rat me out."

"You're sure about that?" Flutterina asked.

"Yeah. If she was gonna, she would've by now. I'm sure." Finn asserted.

"Understood. But you're still gonna need an alibi. Plausible deniability is one thing, but *I* can make it so that nobody even suspects it was you."

"I wish you would."

"Your wish is my command. And I could find out everything you need to know about the Queen's schedule, the guard shifts, and so many other important things."

"I wish you would."

"Your wish is my command!" They said, showing off the form of a Brightmoon Guard.

"I also wish you would tell me a little bit about yourself."

"Your wish is my comm- wait, what?" Flutterina asked, seeming puzzled.

"I know you have to have a job *outside* doing… whatever it is you're doing right now. For all your 'your wish is my command' stuff, you still have to have a life outside of this. It would be narcissistic to assume your whole purpose was to help *me.* "

"Wow. Most of my employers don't seem to get that. I'll bite, kitten. I am… and *actor!* You've seen what I can do. And I don't merely mimic someone's appearance. No, I must understand what they feel and *emulate* it. I can put on such marvelous performances… but it's all fake."

"Of course it is. It's the theatre."

“That’s not what I meant. It’s not true, either. Theatre is the truest lie there is, except love of course. But it comes to my attention that I have not yet reached my full potential. I can’t cry on cue! Sure, I can convince the *audience* to weep enough to flood the Crimson Wastes, but I am not doing my best, and I *know* it. But! I’ve come up with the solution! I am making a great tragedy, a study in dramatic irony and suspense, with a climax that will blow your socks off! It will have a grand journey, full of magic, strange creatures and people, trust and betrayal, violence and bloodshed! If this doesn’t make me cry, for real, I probably just can’t.”

“What’s it about?”

“It’s a surprise.” Flutterina said, blinking innocently.

“I wish you’d tell me.” Flutterina sighed and rubbed their head.

“Your moms really spoiled you, didn’t they? Okay, here goes. It’s about this kid who goes out into the world to kill their mother.”

“What? Why would anyone do that?”

“Well, there are lots of reasons people might want to kill their mothers. Money, power, freedom… but this kid wasn’t after any of that. They didn’t even know it was their own mother they were trying to kill. You see, she had a secret identity, and the kid was raised by one while hating the other.”

“So how does it end?”

“Wow. You’re spoiled enough already.”

“I wish you would tell me.”

“I wish I could. I don’t know how it ends yet.”

“It sounds complicated and unrealistic.”

“Hm, maybe. But I promise you, it’ll bring you to tears when you experience it for real!”

“We’ll see about that, I guess. Hey, what about-”

“Hold it. Something’s getting close. I have to go now. Talk to you later, kitten.” Flutterina turned into a Brightmoon guard and walked away.

“What was that all about?” Finn asked themself. Then they heard it too. A rustling in the bushes. They stared at the shaking leaves. Suddenly, a small grey cat with blue eyes came bounding out. It was only Melog. “Oh, hi Melog. You just missed meeting… well, I’m not sure if I should call them my ‘friend’. To be honest, they kind of give me the creeps. But they’ve been helpful so far. I mean, they’re the one who gave me the idea to kill Catra in the first place.” Melog’s head immediately snapped to look at Finn. “Huh, it’s funny. It’s almost like you understood that. …You know, we should get back to Sparkles’ house, it’s getting late. Come on, Melog.” Melog trotted at Finn’s heel, staring at them intently.

Shelter

Chapter Summary

> Finn visits his aunt and uncle. Catra and Adora check into a hotel.

"Well Finn, welcome to your new hideaway for the time being. Make yourself at home."

"Thanks for helping me with this. Means a lot to me" Finn said.

"Finn, let me make this *absolutely* clear to you," Sparkles explained, "I do *not* approve of this whole… quest of vengeance thing. The only reason I'm helping you is because I don't want to see you get hurt. That, and I owe your moms, BIG time."

"Point still stands. Even more, actually."

"Huh. I sorta thought you'd be mad."

"Of course not! I mean, I probably *would* if you *did* try to stop me or turn me in, but the fact that you're not doing that even though you don't want me to do this… well, like I said, it means a lot."

"That's a very mature way of looking at it, I guess. When I was your age, I probably would have gone all 'if you're not with me, you're against me!' and then tried to boss people around."

"Wait, why were you allowed to boss people around?"

"Well, I was technically a *much* higher rank than your uncle *or* your mom, so I sort of thought I could get away with… whatever I wanted. It was a disaster."

"You know, when you say 'your mom' like that I can't tell which mom you mean. Just use their names, like a normal person, you know?"

“Or I could just let you figure it out with context clues. For instance, your mom was working for me, while your other mom was working for the Horde, so I technically didn’t outrank your mom.”

“Your giving me a headache.”

“You’re.”

“That’s what I said! Ugh, I’m going to bed.” Finn walked up the stairs, Melog trailing after them.

“Make sure you brush your teeth and shower first, or your mom will kill me!” Sparkles said, slyly not mentionning which mom would kill her.

“This is as bad as all those cat puns, except these aren’t technically puns, they’re just low-budget mind games!”

“Oh, you didn’t like the puns? That’s a shame. I thought they were…”

“Don’t.”

“Purr-fect.”

“Aunt Sparkles, I love you, but for the love of Mara please shut up.”

“Such disrespect! Relax, I’m just kitten you.” Sparkles projected for Finn to hear. Agonized pun-induced screaming from the upstairs bathroom.

“Honey, I’m home. I heard Finn screaming. Did you make another cat pun?” Came Uncle King’s voice.

“Well first I softened their brains by playing ‘guess which mom I’m talking about,’ then I dropped *two* cat puns on them!”

“What were they?”

“Purr-fect, and the kitten-kiddin’ mixup.”

“You really are tyrannical.” He said affectionately.

“Yup, I still got it.”

“Hey, I heard the news from Swiftwind, (because of course people leave me out of the plans). Is Finn really here to… you know.”

“They’re certainly gonna try.”

“And we’re just… letting them?”

“We can’t really stop them. Remember how your parents wanted you to be a historian and you became the king instead?” Glimmer whispered. “It’s something like that. If we try to stop them or say they can’t, they’re just gonna do it behind our backs, without our help, and maybe get stabbed by a bad guy.” Bow opened his mouth to protest, but then closed it. Then he opened it again.

“Huh. That is… a weirdly accurate representation of our adolescence. Never thought of it that way before, but- yeah. Still, I’m gonna talk to them.”

“I don’t know. If their moms couldn’t dissuade them, then…”

“Well, I’ve gotta try.” King walked up the stairs and knocked on the door to the guest room.

“Come in.” Finn said. Bow cracked open the door. Finn was sitting on the bed, petting Melog.

“Hey. I heard why you’re here. This must really matter to you.”

“It does.”

“Why?”

“What kind of question is that? She killed my parents. I’m mad. That’s all there is to it.”

“Yeah, I think I kind of get it. But killing Catra… will that really make anything any better? If you go through with this, everything in your life will be the same as before. Except it won’t be the same for you. You will have killed someone. Will it really be worth it?”

“…”

“You don’t have to answer right now. Look, I’m sorry I’m not as supportive as I could be about this. I guess I just don’t really get it. You never really knew your parents, so…”

“That’s the problem. I never knew my parents. And I never will. That’s Catra’s fault. Don’t get me wrong, I love Cat and Addie with my whole heart. But sometimes I wonder about where I came from, you know? What were my parents like?” Finn was quiet for a bit. “You know, I’m not sure if I imagined this or made it up or what, but I think I remember a little bit about one of them.

“Oh. Would you mind telling me about them?”

“I was a baby. Which is part of the reason I think I might have made this up, you know? But it was late, and I was crying about something. I don’t remember what. Then the door opened, and there was this woman standing there. I don’t remember much of what she looked like. Just that she was a cat like me, with a huge mess of hair on her head. I have no idea why I think this, but she seemed… tired. But she came to take care of me anyway. And then I remember her picking me up and rocking me to sleep. I-I think that might have been my real mom. And that’s the only thing I’ll ever know about her, and I don’t even know if it’s real.”

“Oh.” there was silence. “Sorry. I shouldn’t have asked. It was kinda insensitive of me, wasn’t it?”

“Kinda. I appreciate you trying, though. Goodnight, Uncle King.”

“Goodnight, Finn.”

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"So. Bright Moon. It's been a long time."

"Yeah. It really has, hasn't it?" Adora said.

"Wish it could've been for a happier reason though. Maybe, I dunno, anniversary dinner? Field trip? Sleepover with Sparkles and Arrow Boy where we try to steal as much cake as possible because asking politely isn't really all that fun? Also I go here for work like, every day. I guess it could be for that."

"Oh, right. Royal Advisor. Forgot about that."

"Dumbest decision Queenie ever made."

"Explain."

"Royal Advisors typically try to usurp their bosses at some point. I have a history of betraying my bosses."

"Really?"

"Yup. First Shadow Weaver, then Hordak, then Prime…"

"No, I knew about that. The advisor thing."

"Yeah, it's like a law of nature or something. You remember that one play with the weird toucan?"

"I think it was a parrot."

"A what?"

"Okay so a parrot is-"

"Hold on. Getting a transmission from Melog." Catra closed her eyes for a few seconds, then opened them.
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"What did they say?"

"Someone's messing with Finn." Catra growled.

"What? Who?"

"Don't know. Melog didn't meet them or hear their name. We know the following: Finn finds them creepy, but helpful. And they gave Finn the idea to do this whole… thing."

"What? What would even be the point of that?"

"A lot of people have good reasons to be mad at me, Adora."

"But using *Finn* against you? That's just twisting the knife."

"Yeah, it's a little much. I wish whoever it was would leave my kid out of this."

"I wish whoever it was would leave my *wife* out of this."

"Finn's still our priority though."

"Always. Doesn't mean I can't be pissed that this asshole is going after you."

"I'm mostly mad that this jerk won't just come to my face with a sword or whatever if they want me dead this badly."

"No, that's not what they want. They have to know it's us, otherwise they wouldn't have picked Finn to be their assassin. They have to know you're Catra. The question is, if they want you dead, then why haven't they told Finn the truth?"

"I don't know. But I don't think it would work if they did. Imagine, 'Hey kid, Catra killed your parents, you should kill her back. Also your adoptive mom is Catra in disguise. Have fun!' I don't think it would go so well for the guy."

"It's not *gonna* go well for the guy. If I ever find this jerk, I will make what happened to Horde Prime look like a light

admonishment and a time-out by comparison."

"Jeez. I think ripping someone's soul out is bad enough. A little too much even."

"Alright, but consider; this person is messing with Finn."

"... I can see where you're coming from. Point still stands. So where will we be staying?"

"Hotel near the castle. It used to be the guard barracks, but you know, the war ended and most of them retired to civilian lives and stuff. The guards needed to be able to get to the castle immediately in case of emergencies, so it should be the perfect place to camp in case something goes wrong."

"I hate that we have to think like this. Finn's just hanging out at Glimmer's, it should be a safe place for them."

"Yeah, but they're dealing with people we don't know anything about, except that they're willing to put Finn in dangerous situations in order to get at me. Heck, even that's a bit presumptuous. They probably have some kinda grudge against me, but it could be anything. But if I'm right, then that means they might decide to hurt Finn directly in order to get under my skin. It's not like it'd work, they have Melog protecting them. We both know how terrifying it can be. Remember Krytis?"

"How could I forget? Doors just freaking showed up and vanished out of nowhere, we wound up walking in circles, the walls tried to kill us and the floor ate you. Good times."

"Melog's planet had been strip-mined for magic by the First Ones, and *that* was what it was capable of. Now they're on Etheria, and the magic has been released. If anyone tries to hurt our Finn, they're in for a world of pain. And that's *before* we show up, (but not by much since we'll be there immediately.)"

"I know. I'm still worried, though."

“I have an idea. We’ll cuddle. We’ll smooch. We’ll race to see who goes to sleep first, and the loser has to tuck in the winner. Melog will watch over Finn all night, and will wake me up if something goes wrong. But tonight, leave the worrying to the other guys.”

“It still feels bad to pretend like nothing’s wrong right now.”

“We’re not pretending that. Nothing’s okay about any of this at all. We’re just trusting other people to deal with it when we can’t. We don’t have to do everything on our own now, remember? We can let our friends help us with our problems.”

“You’re right. We can trust Bow and Glimmer to make sure Finn is safe, at least for a little while, right?”

“Yeah. And Melog.”

“Yup. Can’t forget Melog. I mean, I’m so used to it being a therapy cat or something that sometimes I forget it can be like a horror movie bad guy when it needs to be. Finn is in good hands.”

“Yeah. Let them take care of Finn for now, and let me take care of you.”

The End of the World All Over Again.

Chapter Summary

Discoveries are made. Secrets are hidden or shared.

Adora wound up winning the race to go to sleep, but that was mainly because Catra was throwing the match by helping Adora fall asleep sooner. Once Catra was certain that she had successfully lost, she tucked Adora into bed, quietly walked to the balcony, and made mental contact with Melog.

Hey, Melog.

Catra. Good to speak with you again.

It's a bit difficult at this distance, but it's good to talk to you too.

Something is bothering you.

I want to deny it, but there's no real point in lying to you, is there? Yes. Something is bothering me.

What is it?

Don't you already know?

No. I can't read your mind unless you let me. Otherwise I only get general ideas and emotions. All of these are either bittersweet or just plain bad.

Sorry. You shouldn't have to deal with that.

That's not the point. What's going on?

Is it too vague to say 'everything?'

Yes. Yes it is.

Fine. I'm worried about Finn. I need to pretend not to be because if Adora catches on then she'll be upset and then I'll be upset that she's upset and then there'll be a never-ending crying loop. Happy?

No. There was radio silence.

I've been thinking about… the secret I'm keeping from Finn. Why I haven't told them the truth, even though I tried. Or at least part of it.

Go on.

If I told Finn the truth, this whole mess would just be resolved. Whatever happened would just happen. But I'm scared.

What are you scared of?

When they find out the truth, I'd like to imagine that nothing would change. That Finn would still love me. That everything would go back to normal, except Adora and I could use our real names. Things would be okay. But when Finn finds out for real… that's not going to happen. They'll hate me. They ***should*** *hate me. Even if they don't go through with their plan… it feels like the end of the world all over again. I know I'm just delaying the inevitable. Whatever happens will happen, and I want to just get it over with. But I just can't.*

And nobody can blame you for that. You love Finn, it's only natural for you to want them to love you too.

I get that it's normal to have emotions, Melog. Problem is I don't know what to do with them. I can't tell Finn. I can't ***not*** *tell Finn. I can't protect them from all the bad stuff. I have to try. I'm clinging too close. I'm not doing enough. I'm just so goddamn tired.*

Then rest.

But then-

It is like you told Adora. The world will not end if you decide to rest for a while.

…

Perhaps you would like to speak with Finn?

Maybe I will, in the morning.

No. Now. It will reassure you.

I don't want to wake them up.

They are not sleeping. Something has them unnerved. I cannot tell what, and I cannot ask them, because I do not have a psychic bond with them and also I am pretending to be an ordinary cat. Call them on your tech pad. See if they'll pick up. She pulled up Finn's name in her contacts and pressed the call button. Finn picked up in the first two rings.

"Good evening, mother. Why'd you call? You woke me up."

"Finn, we both know that's a dirty lie."

"Fine, you caught me. How do you always know these things?"

"Melog told me."

"Fine, keep your secrets. Still though, why'd you call me?"

"Well for starters I miss you."

"Seriously? It's only been a day. …I miss you too, mom. How's Addie doing?"

"She's a nervous wreck right now. Really wants you to be okay, also terrified that someone's already stabbed you to death in a shady allyway. Right now she's sleeping like a baby though."

"But it's Brightmoon. I don't think there *are* any shady allyways here."

“Maybe, but I’m sure you could find some if you tried.”

“Probably. Gotta go somewhere to have secret meetings with informants.”

“Have you had any of those?”

“Well, there’s this one guy. Offered to figure out the guard agendas for me. You know, seeing when they’re on break, and when they get switched out and stuff.”

“Uh-huh. Tell me about them.”

“Okay, their name is Flutterina and-”

“Wait, did you say Flutterina?”

“Yeah, why?”

“Are they pink? With wings and weird big eyes?”

“Sometimes. They shapeshift though.”

“Oh HELL no. Sorry, don’t tell Addie I said that. But I know that guy.”

“Really? What do you know about them?”

“I knew them as Double Trouble. They’re an actor, and also a mercenary. They used to work for me. At the time, I thought that they were my best asset. They could gain all kinds of information, build bonds with people and simultaneously tear friendships apart from the inside. One time they saved me from a burning building. But when the tide of war changed, so did their allegiance. Ultimately it was for the best, but… well, you don’t need to hear the full story. How much are they charging?”

“Nothing.”

“What? What do you mean, nothing? This is Double Trouble, there’s a price for everything. Are they asking for money, favors,

or what?”

“Nothing. They haven’t asked for anything yet.” Catra thought back to what Melog had told her.

“Finn. Are they the one who gave you the idea to go after Catra?”

“Kind of. They are the one who told me about what Catra did in the Horde, but this was my idea. They’re just helping me. They say it’s ‘pro bono’ work, whatever that means.”

“It means that it’s free. But this doesn’t make any sense. Double Trouble was a mercenary through and through. They’re on the side with the money, and on the side that lives, unless it’s ridiculously boring.”

“Maybe working with me is ridiculously interesting?” Finn asked.

“Maybe,” Cat said, unconvinced. “Look, just be careful with them, okay? I’d call them two-faced but they have a *lot* more faces then that.”

“Noted.”

“Hey, I miss you, but it’s getting past your bedtime, and Addie’s grumbling. Talk tomorrow, okay Finn?”

“Goodnight! See you soon.” Finn hung up.

It seems to have helped. The child has gone to bed.

“Well kid, goodnight. Good work. You’ll most likely kill me in the morning.” Catra said to nobody who could hear her.

They should never have shown you that movie.

No, it’s absolutely necessary information hen a princess was going to be my bride.

Who is Double Trouble?

Bastard bitch. Not the help I wanted, but the help I needed and deserved. They told me how much I sucked and it slapped me in the face so hard I did a heel-face turn.

It sounds like they did you a favor.

Yeah, but I trust them about as much as I trust a carton of milk with the expiration date written on in dry-erase marker.

Ew.

Catra dialed up Glimmer and Bow.

"Catra? What are you calling us for? It's late…" Glimmer complained.

"Double Trouble's messing with Finn. They gave them the idea to go after me. Be careful."

"Oh! Woah. That's… bad. What should we do?" Bow asked.

"Look out for weird shapeshifers. If you find them, try to figure out what's going on. Stop it if you can. I'll tell Adora in the morning."

"Got it. We'll keep an eye on Finn for you. Thanks for warning us."

"Goodnight."

"Goodnight, Catra."

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Double Trouble turned off the camera. They had recorded enough.
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"Hello, Finn." Flutterina said.

"Double Trouble. My mom warned me about you."

"Ooh, figured me out, haven't you? Clever kid." Double Trouble shifted into their more familiar form, with their green skin and forked tail. "I'm sure both of your moms have good dirt on me, but guess what? I have better dirt on your aunt and uncle! Take a look~" Double trouble produced a tech pad. "There's a video here. I think you want to watch it."

"I don't want anything to do with this or anything else that has to do with you."

"Oh, you wound me. I promise, no catch, no price for this. I'm doing this because I want to. I'm not gonna make you watch this, but I'll still send it to your datapad. I'm sure you'll get around to it *eventually.* Give me a call when you're ready to talk, kitten!"

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Finn had the program open, their claw an inch away from the play button. But they hesitated. It was from Double Trouble, after all. But what harm could one video do? Finn pressed play. On the screen were Uncle King and Aunt Sparkles sitting on a couch, data pad on Sparkles' lap. Finn couldn't make out who was talking on the other end, but they could hear what King and Sparkles were saying.

"Catra? What are you calling us for? It's late…"

"Oh! Woah. That's… bad. What should we do?"

“Got it. We’ll keep an eye on Finn for you. Thanks for warning us.” Small hesitation. “Goodnight, Catra.”

Real Talk

Chapter Summary

Finn makes a Plan. Catra feels bad about a lot of things. Adora tries to make her stop feeling bad about a lot of things.

"Alright. You have the schedules and maps?"

"Of course!"

"And they're accurate, right?"

"What reason would I have to lie to you?"

"What reason would you have to do any of this?"

"Fair point. But I'm not leading you into a trap. If you have anything in common with *either* of your mothers, that would be a terrible idea. So unless there was some kind of last-minute change, you'll be good to go."

"Got it. Now, I've made plans with Sparkles and King on that day to do some sightseeing in the area. Your mission, should you choose to accept it, is to take my place so they don't realize what I did. Meanwhile, Melog and I will storm the castle." Finn said, picking up the grey cat.

"You sure your cat should be in on this, kitten? I mean, it's a cat."

"The alternative is leaving it with you." Double Trouble looked at Melog, who was staring daggers at them.

"Good call."

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“Adora, we have a problem.”

“What is it?”

“Finn trusts Double Trouble more than they trust Bow and Glimmer.”

“What? Why?!”

“Just getting that bit, hang on.” Catra’s ear twitched as she listened to Melog’s debriefing. “DT showed them a video of Glimmer and Bow conspiring with me, and calling me by my real name.”

“Oh no.”

“Yeah, apparently Sparkles said something like ‘We’ll keep an eye on them for you, Catra,’ and let’s be honest, how else are they gonna interpret it? I’ll text Bow and Glimmer the news.” Catra stared into the distance as she received new information from Melog. “They’re leaving DT behind as a decoy while they go after me. Gosh, that’s so *smart.* You know, I did something like that once, while I was still working with Double Trouble? I had them turn into me and go after you while I was doing other stuff.”

“Still not good that they trust DT.”

“Well with the information they have, it makes sense to. Can’t blame them for not having all the facts, especially when we’re the ones who are hiding them.”

“Fair point.”

“This raises the question about what we’re gonna do now. We know what they’re gonna do and when they’re gonna do it. If I just keep not being there when I’m upposed to, they might realize that I know what they’re up to and get paranoid. We don’t want that.”

“Well obviously we set a trap.”

“Adora, this is *Finn.* We’re not leading them into an ambush.”

“Not an ambush! Well, not a real one, anyway. Maybe like a pit trap or a net or something.”

“Hm. We escape without me dying, at at the same time, Finn realizes they’re on the right track, maybe don’t realize we’re keeping tabs on them more then they already get. Drop a hint later that sends them on a wild goose chase to a place that’s probably not gonna kill them, like Mystacor or something… I see where you’re going with this!”

“I actually wasn’t thinking that far ahead. I just thought ‘we can’t just disappear’ and ‘we can’t hurt Finn’ and that seemed like the best response.”

“Still a good idea. Hm. We’ll have to send the guards away so that they don’t get involved in this. They take their jobs pretty seriously and I doubt they’d just let Finn go after, you know, attempted murder.”

“Fair point. I’ll just say you don’t need a bodyguard because your superpowered wife is with you. They’ll understand, maybe take the day off for some ice cream or something.”

“And I’ll call the queen’s aunt.”

“You mean Castaspella?”

“Dear lord that’s a dumb name.”

“You are literally called Catra.”

“Rude. If you are going to insult my name, at least use the whole thing. I am Catra Applesauce Meowmeow-Rainbowfist.”

“Wow, I forgot about all that.”

“How? How did you forget about that? It was hilarious!”

"Well, we've been using fake names for so long that- nevermind. Just refresh me on the story."

"I lost a bet when we were choosing our whole official names, and you got to pick mine. I got pissy for no reason even though the bet was my idea and then you let me pick your name to make me feel better."

"Wow, that's dumb."

"...There's something I never told you about that day. I wanted to give you the same last name I had. I wanted to name you Adora Happysmile Meowmeow. Because, you see, I'd read a few contraband books from the Rebellion, and I heard about marriage and the whole last name thing so- I eventually decided against it, but you get the point."

"Aw, Catra! That's so *sweet!* "

"No, it was stupid. I was stupid. Already thinking about marriage when I was too chicken to even ask you out."

"While we're reminiscing, do you remember how we wound up with Finn?" Adora asked.

"Of course, Adora. I could never forget that. We decided we'd reached the point where we should adopt a child of our own."

"Yeah. I originally wanted to choose, like, a baby. Because that's what kids start as, right? And Finn wasn't a baby. But then you saw them, and- I'm still not entirely certain what happened. But it was like you two instantly clicked. I still remember what you said. 'Adora, I want *this* one.' And you made the right choice. You know, you never did tell me why you wanted Finn in particular." Adora cocked her head to the side, waiting for an answer to the implied question.

"I- It's not- It's probably just a coincidence, but I heard the name before and- nevermind. It's not something I want to talk about right now. Bad memories."

“I get it. You don’t have to tell me if you don’t want to. But whatever it was, it brought Finn into our lives, and it’s wonderful. I mean, present circumstances excluded.”

“No. I think it’s worth it.” Catra sighed. “... This is so messed up, Adora.”

“In general? Yeah, pretty much. Can’t get much worse than this. But I feel like you might be talking about something more specific.”

“The whole Finn thing. I mean, when you think about it I basically killed two people and stole their child. That’s… it never really clicked for me until they started talking about this whole plan thing, but that’s just what I did.”

“Catra, that’s not what happened!”

“How is it not what happened? That’s exactly what happened!”

“Well first of all, it was a war. You weren’t killing people so you could have Finn, or whatever it was you think you did.”

“Yeah, I was killing them for no reason at all, like that’s so much better!”

“Well what about Scorpia?”

“Well what about her?”

“Scorpia and Entrapta and Kyle and Lonnie and Rogelio and all the rest of them. They all killed people in th Horde. Are they bad people?”

“It’s- It’s different, with them, okay? They only did what *I* told them to. *They* didn’t do what I did. *They* didn’t lead the attacks, or make plans, and most importantly *they* didn’t trick some kid they orphaned into loving them.”

"They don't love you because you tricked them, they just love you. Is that really so hard for you to believe?"

"Yes, Adora. Yes, it is hard for me to believe. The only reason we were able to become close at all is because I've been lying to them. I never told them the truth, and if I did then they'd hate me."

"Is that really what you think?"

"Yes."

"Then I don't know what to tell you. Finn loves you for actual real reasons, not because you stole them or tricked them. You're a good mom, you know that? You're their favorite. When those kids were mean to them at school, they went to *you* for a shoulder to cry on. When they have homework problems, they come to *you* for help. And don't even get me started on the food thing. They want your approval, your affection, and you're all too happy to give it to them. And I'd be lying if I said I wasn't jealous. But don't you *dare* tell me all of that is fake. And yes, lying for so long was a bad idea, but it was *my* idea."

"And I went along with it. I could have said no, insisted on at least telling *Finn* the truth at some point."

"Look, am I bad for hiding the truth from Finn?"

"No."

"Is Scorpia bad for killing people in the Horde?"

"No, but-"

"No buts. You're not a bad person, Catra."

"Well, Finn seems to disagree."

"Finn seems to be on *several* minds on the subject."

“Fair point. But they only like me at all because-”

“Zip it. ZIP. IT. Finn loves you because you’re you. They think they hate Catra, (who they don’t know is you) because Double Trouble tricked them. I mean think about it this way. They have two opinions, one from Double Trouble and one from you. Both are conflicting, and one must be accurate. Which one is the lie?”

“Double Trouble, obviously. …Thanks, Adora. And- sorry.”

“Hey, it’s no problem. I’ll always be here to talk you out of this stuff. Seriously though, you really thought all those bad things about yourself? And *you* call *me* a dumbass.”

“Well, yeah. You’re the one who used Sea Hawk’s ‘Anchor’ line on me, remember?”

“Guilty as charged.” Adora looked at Catra. “So, do you feel better now?”

“Sorta. It helps, but you know. It can only do so much.”

“Yeah, I guess. Sucks that a kiss can save the universe, but not all this.”

“I mean… it couldn’t hurt, could it?”

“No. It couldn’t.” They kissed.

Mission Improbably

Chapter Summary

Plans are made and put into motion. Finn gets a makeover.

"So, where to first? The park? The museum? I'm just *so* excited to spend the day with my aunt and uncle!"

"You can drop the act. We know you're not Finn." Glimmer said.

"You've got me dead to rights. How ever did you figure it out?" Double Trouble asked, shifting back into their own form.

"Heard it from a friend, who heard it from a friend. Now where's my nephew?"

"Oh I'd just *love* to tell you, but… I actually can't think of anything, I just don't want to tell you."

"Fine then. Be that way. I guess I have to drag the truth out of you the hard way." Glimmer drew a circle in the air which was soon decorated with geometric symbols, runes, and the phases of the moon. *Something* rose from the ground, something in a shade of purple dark enough to be mistaken for black, something that writhed like agonized eels and whispered something-

" *Or* we could just use a truth spell." Bow pointed out.

"And *you* went straight to the dark magic torture spell. I wonder if you let Catra go just because you knew that there was nothing she did that you didn't do worse? I mean, you didn't do *everything* she did, but then again, the Horde didn't *have* civilians to target, did they?"

"Shut up! SHUT UP!" Glimmer cast the truth spell. "Now tell me what you did to Finn!"

"I didn't do anything to Finn, except talk."

"Then where are they?"

"Where they want to be."

"And where's that?"

"The place where they are currently."

"Tell me something *useful!"* Double Trouble laughed.

"I did a bit of research on this whole 'magic' thing you've got going after the last time a truth spell got put on me. I have to answer your questions, and I can't lie. But that doesn't mean you can just order me around, that's not what the spell does. I can be as vague and irritating as I want."

"...I'm doing the torture spell."

"Glimmer, NO-"

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"Alright Melog. Moment of truth. We kill Catra, or we die or something." Melog gave Finn a look. "Oh don't look at me like that! You knew this was what you were signing up for when you decided you wanted to come with me." Melog blinked. "Good. I knew you'd come around eventually. Now let's kick butt!" Melog made a sort of disgruntled noise but followed at Finn's heels.

The palace was empty for the most part. Finn had expected *some* guards, but there were none to be seen. Did Double Trouble trick them? Had Sparkles or King found their notes and ratted them out to the guards? Was this a trap of some kind? Better to be safe than sorry. Melog went ahead so that any ambushes would wind up getting a false start, thereby warning Finn of their presence. It's kind of like that thing in horror movies where somebody
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expects an attack but then a cat jumps out of a cupboard so they feel relieved that it wasn't that, but then the bad guy shows up right behind them.

But no ambush happened. No traps were sprung. All the places Double Trouble had said would be guarded just *weren't.* Something was wrong. Something was *very, very,* wrong. But Finn wasn't going to let a *lack* of problems stop them. That'd just be stupid. So they continued to where DT's notes had said Catra was going to be. They heard voices through the door. Peeping thorough the keyhole, Finn saw two women at a table. One was obviously a magicat, the other was glowing. The magicat was wearing a hood and a domino mask, with a scarf covering her face. The other woman, Finn recognized somewhat from the art people had made in her honor. She-Ra. Her face was also obscured with an armored helmet. That would explain the lack of guards. She-Ra was an army on her own, any assailants would be thoroughly outclassed in a head-on fight.

Finn weighed their options. Catra had no known supernatural abilities, aside from rumors of a shapeshifting alien pet that were almost certainly made up. She did, however, have years of combat training and could allegedly go toe-to-toe with She-Ra without being scratched. Even if she didn't have She-Ra guarding her, initiating a direct conflict would be instant death. Better to pretend to be a lost tourist, then claw Catra's neck when she lowered her guard. But Catra had already known they were a threat. Sparkles had warned her. Maybe Finn could wait for them to leave the room. They had to do that eventually, right? If Catra opened the door first, they could pounce immediately. If She-Ra opened the door first, Finn would hide behind it and attack when Catra walked through. All they had to do was wait and watch.

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“But what if-”

“Sh.” Catra whispered. “They’re here.”

“They are?” Adora whispered back.

“Yup. I’ll call Queenie to get us out of here. Kid’s waiting at the keyhole. Probably trying to see which one of us goes for the door first. Here’s the plan. You go first, I go immediately behind you. Right before you open the door (casually) I bend down to tie my shoelace or something. Finn whiffs attacking nothing. Then you turn the sword into a lasso to restrain them until we make our getaway to Mystacor.”

“Yeah, we could *all* use a vacation after this.”

“Yeah, sure. Vacation. With water and sorcerers and stuff. Great.”

“Hey, you liked it last time!”

“You’re right, I did. You ready to walk into an ambush?”

“Always am!”

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Finn could see that She-Ra was walking towards the door. After Catra had been defeated, Finn could make a break for the window, and Double Trouble would take the credit for the assassination later, and Finn would get off scot-free. This is the greatest plan.

She Ra opened the door and walked through. Once she had advanced a significant amount, Finn attacked, striking their claws at-
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Absolutely nothing. Catra wasn't there at all, but a few paces behind, tying her shoelace. It was just bad luck, but she was still off guard. If they acted quickly, they could-

Suddenly something wrapped around their waist. The sword of protection, in the form of a lasso, had caught them mid-leap and tugged them back.

"It's alright, Catra!" She-Ra said. "You are safe now."

"Um. Cool." Said Catra awkwardly. "Ugh, this was exhausting. First we needed to figure out that disaster relief thing, then tax reform, and now an assassination attempt. I need a vacation."

"And I know just the thing!" Said She-Ra, with conspicuously exaggerated boisterousness. "Mystacor! The most relaxing place on Etheria!" Why the hell did She-Ra sound like a tourism brochure, and why would she say where Catra would b going in front of the assassin who just tried to kill her?

She's lying. Finn realized. *They're trying to get me to waste my time in Mystacor while they escape and cover their tracks.*

"Why are you helping her?" Finn asked. "Why are you letting her escape?! You're *She-Ra.* You're supposed to be the protector of Etheria, you're supposed to be one of the good guys! So why the hell are you helping Catra? She hurt so many people, she hurt my parents, she shouldn't get to just walk free after that! She deserves to *die!* So why? Because you *love* her, she gets to get away with everything she did? You're no hero, you're just SELFISH!" She-Ra's confident facade dropped immediately.

"I just- I-" She sounded lost.

"Hey. Finn, right?" Catra interrupted. "Look, you're right about a lot. I *did* hurt a lot of people, and I *do* deserve to die. No matter what Adora has to say on the subject. But leave my *wife* out of this. After everything, she deserves to be a little selfish."

“Well, I guess you would say that. It all worked out for *you,* didn’t it?” Finn said, still trying to slice through the lasso that had tied them up.

“I guess it did, huh?” Catra pondered. “Come on, Adora. Let’s go.” She paused. “Hey Finn? For what it’s worth, I’m sorry. For everything.”

“It’s worth nothing. Let me go!”

“I figured as much. Don’t worry, that rope thing will disappear when we’re gone. You’ll be free to go and attack me some other time, if you want. Until we meet again, Finn.”

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“So, kitten. How’d it go?” Double Trouble asked.

“Terribly. The ambush backfired. She-Ra tied me up and then they both walked away.”

“So what now?”

“Let me ask you for a favor, DT.”

“Fire away.”

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“How do I look?”

“Perfect. You might not be able to shapeshift like me, but you sure can pull off a transformation! I mean, people who know you won’t

be tricked, but a description they give to someone else won't be accurate any longer. Am I missing anything? Let's see… hair dye, edgy haircut, complete wardrobe change, bandanna, thigh holster… you'll fit right in where you're going!"

"Great. I'll call the sea captain."

"They didn't even stay to finish me off. They just left me tied up and walked away." Finn said.

"I don't think I get it. Did you… *want* them to kill you? Because in my opinion them deciding not to is definitely for the better." Addie pointed out.

"No I didn't want them to kill me! But it felt… I dunno, like they thought killing me would have been a waste of their time. It's just weird."

"So, where are you going to go next?"

"Home, I guess. This mission was a dead end."

"Wait. You're giving up? Just like that?" Addie asked, confused.

"Don't sound so shocked. You're the one who said this idea was bad, you were right. There's nothing more to it."

"I guess. See you soon, Finn!"

"Yeah, see you real soon." Finn ended the call.

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Swift Wind landed in the backyard. Cat and Addie were waiting outside."
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“Hey you two. Brought your kid back.” Swift Wind said. “Note to self: loop de loops with cat people on board will result in an immediate need for first aid, because they hold on tighter so as not to fall, and they *tend to hold on with their claws.* ”

“Finn! You’re back!” Cat said eagerly. “How was your first adventure? Tell us all about it! We have *so* much to talk about!”

“You’re right, we do have a lot to talk about. Like how you killed my parents.” ‘Finn’ said offhandedly. Swiftwind, Catra and Adora froze in shock.

“What did you just say?” Catra asked.

“You killed my parents, Catra.” ‘Finn’ stated with an eerie calm. “And you never even told me. You tried *so hard* to be a good mother to me. But it was never real at all, was it? And you. Adora. *She-Ra.* You let this all happen. You were supposed to take care of us, but-”

“Enough. You’re not Finn.” Catra glared at the person in front of them. Finn’s shape collapsed into a vaguely green shadow before stretching into the shapeshifter’s favorite form. Double Trouble.

“Ugh, you got me. That’s the second time today, I must be getting rusty.”

“Where are they? Where is Finn?”

“Glimmer asked me the same question earlier. The truth spell didn’t work out the way she expected, so she tried a torture spell. But you know magic like that doesn’t work unless you want it to, so-” Double trouble shifted into a very distressed and disheveled looking younger Catra. “Why? Why? You did this! You did this to me!” They laughed and dropped the disguise again. “You’d be surprised at how much people can change. During the war, she actully took a break from her mission *specifically* to zap the bejeezus out of you. Now though… it leaves a bad taste in her mouth.”

"Wait, Glimmer did *what?*"

"Not important right now, Adora." She turned to Double Trouble, claws unsheathed. "What's important is that you take us to Finn. Right. Now."

A Waste of Time

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra capture Double Trouble. Finn heads to what used to be the Crimson Wastes.

Finn snuck off of the cargo transport they had stowed away on. The strange and alien plants that surrounded them proved that they were exactly where they needed to be; The Crimson Wild. It used to be a desert called 'The Crimson Wastes," but after Etheria's magic was released it had been transformed into an equally hostile jungle that served the same sorts of people that it had before: those who were running away from something.
It didn't take a genius to guess that's where Catra was most likely to be hiding. Legends had it that she'd conquered the place in a day and a night when she'd been exiled from the Horde. It only made sense for her to seek it out again after the dust settled and the blood dried. All Finn had to do now was find her. They suddenly felt something nudge at them.
"Melog? What are you doing here? I sent you with Double Trouble!" Melog meowed. "...Glad you're here though. It's nice to see a familiar face.

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"Alright, you have one more chance to tell us where Finn is before I-"
"Before you do what? Scratch me? Puh-lease, you would never."
"Try me."
"I have been trying you for the past ten minutes, and you're just not going to do anything. You're holding back on me, aren't you?"
"What makes you think that?"
"Well at first I thought you'd lost your edge. But after careful examination I found you're just as sharp and pointy as before. You just don't want to be. You want to pretend to be a good person because it makes people like you, and this whole thing with Finn is just the icing on the cake. You want to prove them
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wrong. If it weren't for that? You would have gutted me like a fish the second I showed up."
"... You're right." Catra finally sheathed her claws. "I'm not going to hurt you."
"Fuck it. I AM going to hurt you!" Adora grabbed DT by the throat and lifted them off the ground.
"ADORA!" Catra yelled.
"Where is Finn!? I've had it up to HERE with your bullcrap, now answer me!"
"Adora , put them down! PUT THEM DOWN!"
"Why should I?" Adora, now in She-Ra's form (when did that happen?) continued to glare at the struggling shapeshifter.
"Melog just found Finn. They're in the Crimson Wild." Adora let Double Trouble drop to the ground.
"...I wasn't expecting that."
"Hold your tongue or I'll rip it out of your head. You have nothing to say to me that I care about." Double Trouble nodded. "Catra, you know a way to keep them tied up and make it stick?"
"No, but there's this plant that used to grow in the Wastes that froze people solid."
"Okay, that'll have to do. Guess what, 'Flutterina,' you're going on a road trip with us!" Double Trouble had the feeling that they had bitten off more than they could chew.

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Finn entered the bar DT had told them about. The hustle and bustle and general chaos within immediately turned into an awkward silence They looked around. Catra was not here, but maybe someone would know where she was?
"Um. Hello. I am looking for Catra?"
"Join the club, kid." Said a scrawny goat person in a leather jacket. "The names Kyle." They said proudly. "It's the name Catra gave me when she ruled the Wastes."
"Their name is Brett." The bartender, a purple lady with a lot of muscles, called. "They got kidnapped by Catra once and made it their entire identity." She glared at them.
"Catra is the strongest in the Crimson Wastes, and don't you forget it! She defeated you, Tung Lashor, She-Ra, Hordak, and
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Horde Prime. The only reason she hasn't com to take the wastes back yet is because-"
"Because she's sick of all this garbage gang fighting and decided to settle down somewhere nice, probably."
"No. Catra's gonna come back, just you wait and see. And when she does…"
"We'll all pay for doubting her inevitable return as the iron-fisted tyrant of the Crimson Wild, we get it. Geez, all the same. Hey kid, c'mere." The purple lady waved Finn over. Finn walked to the bar where she was standing. "Name's Huntara. They used to call me the Princess of the Crimson Waste. Of course they don't call me that anymore, because Catra usurped me and the Wastes are the Wild now. You're not from around these parts, I can tell. You're soft. Soft and fluffy. Nothing wrong with that, you just gotta keep your head down so it'll stay on your shoulders sometimes. So, what business do you have with Catra?"
"I'm going to kill her." Huntara did a double take at Finn.
"You. You gotta be kidding me." She started laughing. "Oh wow. That's just-" She paused to catch her breath. "Sorry. Sorry. You caught me off guard there. Don't know why I was surprised. Prime was defeated by a bunch of teenagers after all."
"So do you know where she is?"
"No. Sorry kid, she's not here."
"SHE'S HERE!" Someone yelled, bursting through the door. "Catra. Catra came back!"
"Crap. Kid, hide under the table or something." Finn crouched under a nearby table, and Huntara deployed the tablecloth, leaving the kid in near-total cover. "Anyone who rats out the kitten is on my list, got it?" There was a murmur of acknowledgement. The door swung open and the bar fell silent.
"I'm looking for a kid." Finn chanced a glance around the tablecloth that concealed them. There in the bar were Catra and She-Ra. Over She-Ra's shoulder was Double Trouble, frozen solid.
"Catra. I thought you retired."
"I could say the same for you."
"So. You're looking for a kid, huh?"
"Cat kid. About this-" She probably indicated a hight. "-tall. Blue eyes. Their name is Finn, but they might lie about that. Their hair

is usually tan-brown, but last I heard they'd dyed it blonde."
"Interesting. So, your voice changed a lot."
"It's from age."
"So you've gotten old, then. Old and soft."
"Maybe I have. Maybe not. Want to find out?"
"You won't find the kid here, Force Captain."
"They're nearby. I can smell it." Finn suddenly wished they'd taken a more thorough bath last night.
"Maybe they are near. Doesn't mean you'll find them."
"No. It doesn't." Catra turned to the rest of the patrons gathered in the bar. "But maybe one of you can. If you find out where they are, or where they're going, contact me. You'll figure out how."
There were footsteps, then the bar door swung open and shut again.
"Alright Finn, it's okay to come out now." Finn came out of their hiding spot. "Well, I guess she's here now. What the heck is is that all about?"
"Tried to kill Catra. Got a stroke of bad luck, she survived. Now she and her magic wife are trying to hunt me down and kill me."
"Huh. Sucks to be you, then. I get the feeling that's not all there is to it, though. She had She-Ra with her. Even if they are a couple now, I don't think Adora would just go along with killing some kid. There's gotta be more to this."
"Adora?"
"Yeah, it's She-Ra's real name."
"Huh…"
"What, you thought she was just always She-Ra, all the time? No. Who could handle that kind of pressure? And besides, she wasn't always She-Ra. She used to be a Horde soldier. Then she saw what the Horde was doing and decided to switch sides, like I did."
"You know, my mom did something similar. My other mom stayed in the Horde until Prime showed up, but then decided to help the Rebellion fight him."
"Huh." Huntara seemed to be thinking about something. "Well, whatever's going on with Adora and Catra and you, I really shouldn't be getting more involved than I already am. But still. If you need a place to hide out, or some food and drink you can know for sure isn't poisonous, I guess I could make a deal with

you.”
“What kind of deal?”
“I’ve got errands to run, chores to do around the bar. You help out around here for a bit, and I’ll make sure you’re as safe as can be! Which still isn’t very safe. It’s the Crimson Wild, after all.” Finn thought about it.
“Sure. When do I start?”
“Right now, I think your priorities would be chasing down Catra before the trail gets cold. So if you still need it by tomorrow, work starts at 8:30. If you’ve already killed Catra by then, no big deal. See you later. Or not.”

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Finn wasn’t planning to kill Catra that night. I mean, if they had the opportunity, they’d go for it. But tonight, they had a different goal. Save Double Trouble.
“Alright Melog, here’s the plan. You just… do you cat stuff or whatever, but stay quiet. I’ll be right back after I save DT.” Melog gave Finn a look. “Good kitty! Now just stay here for a bit.” Finn followed the footprints in the sand. Catra left her own prints that could be called paw prints or footprints depending on what parts you focussed on. She-Ra was likely the one who had large bootprints, and the broad strokes across the mud that made it look like something was being dragged… that had to be Double Trouble. And that smell in the air only proved that She-Ra and Catra had been here. A strange, strong smell that drowned out everything else that Finn had first noticed during their ill-fated ambush. All they had to do now was follow their nose.
The smell led to a clearing, in which Finn could see the two of them resting on a fallen log in front of a campfire. Double Trouble’s frozen body was left on top of a strange cactus-like plant. Finn could still see their eyes moving around, so they had to be conscious. Catra and She-Ra were talking about something.
“-Really worried about Finn.”
“Yeah. Crimson Wastes is no place for a kid that young. The sooner we find ‘em, the sooner we get them home safe.” So that’s why She-Ra was helping Catra. Interesting. But was Catra telling the truth?
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“So, She-Ra changed again.”
“Yeah. I see you have a mask now. That’s new.”
“Yeah. It feels weird, you know? She-Ra reflect things that are important to me. You know, the chest heart from Bow, the winged shoes from Glimmer, your weird… headpiece thingy. But the mask is new.”
“Convenient for us but… I wonder what it means.” There was a solemn, contemplative silence.
Their voices were different than they had been at Huntara’s tavern and somehow familiar. Their masks distorted their voices somewhat so Finn couldn’t put their finger on where they’d heard either before. No matter, it wasn’t important. They just needed to sneak around and-
Melog let out a loud yowl.
“Who’s there?” Catra leapt to her feet. “Finn? Is that you?” Her voice went back to how it had been at the tavern. “Listen, kid. I get why you’d think I’d be here. You were right, Mystacor was a red herring. Smart. But I don’t live in the Crimson Wild, or Beast Island, or any other weird dangerous no-man’s land. I’ve had enough adventure for one lifetime, thank you very much.”
“Yeah. ‘Adventure.’ Like conquering my hometown. That was ‘adventurous’ right?” Finn accused, stepping out of the shadows. Catra flinched and She-Ra looked at the ground.
“I’m sorry. But that doesn't really matter. Sorry doesn’t fix anything. I really am sorry, though.”
“You’re right. It doesn’t fix anything, and it doesn’t matter.” Finn pounced, claws extended. Catra dodged to the side, hands in her pockets. They made to attack again, but something changed. There was a noise that was something like a whale. And then, al of a sudden, Catra and She-Ra just disappeared. “Where did you go? Come back here you cowards!” Melog ran up to Finn and rubbed its head against them. “Good job, the ambush was ruined.” Melog raised an eyebrow and then turned to look at Double Trouble, who was still stuck in the cactus things. “Oh right. Let’s get you out of there.”

Double Digits

Chapter Summary

> DT unfroze. There is a kidnapping. Melog goes full horror-movie villain on some bad guys.

Finn sat Double Trouble next to the fire and waited for whatever it was that had frozen them to wear off. The strange gray shell on their skin eventually began to crack, break, split, and eventually shatter, leaving DT crumpled and gasping for air.

"Hey, you're free! That's great!"

"Well *that* was unpleasant."

"How do you feel? Do you need anything?"

"Some water would be nice." Finn handed them a canteen. "Thanks." DT took a long drink, then set the canteen down. "I don't get it though. Why did you help me?"

"Well, you've been helping me too. I don't really know why, but I figured I needed to return the favor. Besides, I like you." Double Trouble hesitated, taking another drink.

"...Well you shouldn't. Still. I- I appreciate it. Thank you." There was a bit of an awkward silence. "So, how's the Crimson Wastes been treating you?"

"I think they call it the Crimson Wild now. Because She-Ra brought back all those plants?"

"Oh, right. Dumb name. Still, hows it been?"

"Oh, you know. Got a job at the tavern while I'm here."

"Huntara's tavern?"

"Yeah."

"Nice place. Just do me a favor and don't tell her about me, mkay? Alright, I don't want to impose on you anymore. You've got things to do and people to kill. I'll just-" Double Trouble tried to stand up, only to wobble over and fall down. "Sorry. Just a little stiff from being frozen solid."

"Okay then. You're staying with me."

"What?!"

"You heard me. Catra and She-Ra are after you now. Until you get better, I am going to be taking care of you. Okay?"

"That's dumb. I can take care of myself. I'll just turn into someone they aren't looking for." Double Trouble shifted into the form of a random old lady. "See?" The form dissolved back into Double Trouble again. "Crap. That's never happened before."

"That settles it. I'm taking care of you until you get better. If I let you go, those two are just going to catch you again and I don't want to have to rescue you *twice.* "

"Fair enough," Double Trouble conceded. "But just so you know, I think your cat wants to kill me."

"Don't be silly! Melog's harmless." Melog stared daggers at Double Trouble. DT gulped.

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"Double Trouble is probably unfrozen by now."

"Don't worry. Melog's keeping an eye on them. If they try anything, they'll be kitty litter before they can blink."
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“Still don’t like that they’re messing with Finn.”

“Neither do I, but we can’t do anything about it right now.”

“That doesn’t exactly make me feel any better about things, Catra!”

“I know. It shouldn’t. But I pointed it out because freaking out now *won’t* help Finn. We both need to rest.”

“No, we don’t. *You* do. I can just heal my sleep deprivation away with She-Ra. It’s what I did back in the Rebellion when I didn’t have eight hours to waste.”

“Wait, doesn’t magic healing leave the pain behind afterwards?”

“Yes, but the point is I stay fully functional and battle ready!”

“... You know, back in the Horde, I always thought about what your life in the Rebellion was like. It was a way to stay mad at you when I missed you wo much. I imagined cakes and parties and soft beds and new friends and stuff like that. I thought you had everything. But then when I joined the Rebellion, I saw what your life was. When Shadow Weaver revealed that the Failsafe would destroy its host, everyone was horrified. But they were still just going to let you march up to the Heart of Etheria and die. And you were going to just go through with it.” Catra took a deep breath in before pausing to consider her next words.

“You’ve been jumping into fire for everyone else,” Catra continued, “over and over and over again. Now it’s like when someone you care about is in danger, you go looking for the nearest fire. But that won’t help Finn right now. So if you can’t help Finn, why don’t you just… help yourself?” Adora just sort of looked at Catra with that stupid expression that was just so *Adora* that Catra loved so much she hated.

“But it feels bad to relax while Finn’s in danger.” Adora complained.

"Yes, it does. But you know what? Us *not* relaxing won't make Finn safe."

"I'm going to rip Double Trouble in half."

"Only *after* you get eight hours of sleep. And *not* in front of Finn. Okay?"

"...Okay. I'll go to sleep."

"Good." Catra flopped over Adora. "Remember. Cat sleeping on top of you. It's illegal for you to move now."

"It is." Adora conceded. So she didn't move, and neither did Catra. And then they both fell asleep.

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"Good morning. Feeling any better?"

"Hang on." Double Trouble flexed their hand, briefly turning it into Finn's before it snapped back into their own. "No, sorry kitten. Still can't transform."

"Guess you're staying with me for a bit then. I'll be right back with provisions after work, Melog will keep you company while I'm gone." Melog jumped onto Double Trouble's chest in a way that would have seemed 'friendly housecat' if it didn't seem so 'jump on you so I can hold you down while I slice your throat.'

"...Be back soon, okay kitten?" Double Trouble nervously requested nervously, not taking their eyes off of Melog.

"Yeah, real soon. Okay, goodbye then!" Finn vanished into the bushes. Melog watched them go, then turned back to the shapeshifter beneath them.
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“Um, nice kitty?” Double Trouble said. Melog growled, then transformed into its giant panther form with the magical glowing mane and tail. “Oh for the love of-”

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“Good work today, kid. As promised, food and drink.” Huntara handed Finn a strange looking plant and their canteen, which had been recently refilled. “Room’s upstairs, here’s the key.”

“Alright, I’ll just go and get my stuff.” Finn navigated back to the clearing in the woods where they had been previously camped. There, they saw Double Trouble, covered in their own blood.

“DT! What on Etheria happened to you?”

“Finn. Your cat is Satan.” the shapeshifter deadpanned. Finn looked over to where Melog was sitting, innocently licking its paws.

“My moms packed a first aid kit in my supplies. Hey, is peroxide or iodine dangerous for your species?”

“No?”

“Then hold still.” Finn produced a spray bottle and a roll of gauze. “This will probably sting, but we don’t want you to get an infection. Where all are you hurt?”

“Face. Arms. Back.”

“Good. It didn’t go for the throat.”

“It tried.”

“Ah.”
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“You said it was harmless.”

“It usually is. Guess it just really doesn’t like you.” DT hissed as Finn applied the iodine to their cuts. “I said *hold still* , it’ll only hurt worse if you squirm.” Finn suddenly sniffed the air. “Wait a sec. Something’s wrong.”

“Attack!” Someone yelled from the bushes. A net dropped down from the forest canopy above, snagging Finn, Melog, and Double Trouble.

“At this point this might as well happen. Why not?” Double Trouble complained.

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“Ugh.”

“Ugh is right. This stinks.”

“Hey! Melog! You just sliced me to ribbons, can’t you do something about all this?” Melog meowed innocently and then started licking themself. “Of *course* you’d play dumb right now.”

“Quiet, prisoners! We’re still deciding what to do with you!” Goat-Kyle snapped.

“I say we kill ‘em now. That way they can’t escape!” said a goon, who brandished a dagger to prove his point.

“No you dolt! What if Catra wants them alive?” Pointed out another goon. “We still don’t know why Catra’s after this kid.”

“We know enough. The kid said they want to kill her, and they’re clearly enough of a threat for her to go aftr them personally. All in favor of stabbing the brat before anything else happens?” Many
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hands raised. “Alright, then it’s decided…” Melog pounced, roaring as it turned into its larger, more intimidating form. “What the *fuck?”*

“What the *fuck?”* Finn yelled.

“I told you, your cat is Satan.” Double Trouble deadpanned. And then, the room went dark.

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“Adora, wake up.”

“Hm?”

“Melog sent me an alarm. Finn’s in trouble. It had to blow its cover.”

“Crap! Where are they?”

“They got ambushed where they set up camp. Melog *probably* has things handled, but we might as well show up to set the record straight with Kyle’s little fan-club.”

“Right. Give me a second, though. *For the honor of Greyskull!”* There was a sound like a symphony of brass instruments as Adora was transformed into She-Ra, princess of power.”

“I’ll never get over how cool that is.”

“No time.”

“Right.

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“What the hell just happened?”

“Where are the prisoners?”

“Where the hell are we?”

“Oh, hey! Kyle and friends.” That voice was unmistakable.

“Catra! You came back! We had the brat and we were gonna finish them off, but then that weird cat thing-” Kyle saw the strange glowing panther creep up behind Catra’s back. “Boss! Look out! It’s-” The strange creature nuzzled against Catra’s leg.

“It’s doing exactly what I wanted it to do. I wasked you to tell me if you knew anything about Finn. I *didn’t* ask you to murder them. You went *way to far.* That kid is *mine* , you understand?” Razor sharp spikes sprouted out of the ground to reach for their necks.

“Yes, ma’am!” The Crimson Wild gangsters answered.

“And don’t you forget it.” The spikes and the supernatrual darkness dissappated. Catra walked over to where Finn was now visible, still tied up with Double Trouble. They looked her in the eyes.

“What, you gonna kill me now?” Catra unsheathed her claws. Finn braced themself for the inevitable end and-

It didn’t happen. They looked down. The ropes that had tied them up had been snapped cleanly down the middle.

“Catch up with you later, kid. Or you’ll catch up with me. Who knows.” Finn and Double Trouble ran away, and Melog loped after them. Catra and Adora watched them leave. “Well, we’ve got things to do, so we’ll be seeing you later. Until then…” Her eyes narrowed. “ *Don’t* attack Finn again. Have fun.” Catra and She-Ra calmly walked away.

Regrets

Chapter Summary

No more tears of laughter.

Catra vs Finn happens.

BOATS!

Finn, Double Trouble, and Melog (now a housecat) burst into Huntara's tavern. "Alright, we're in the clear."

"Kid. You didn't mention you had company." Huntara pointed out. Finn had a small panic, remembering that Double Trouble had asked them not to talk about them around Huntara.

"They didn't." Finn turned around to see that DT had assumed a new face and voice already. "I mean, they don't. We just happen to both be running from the same thing at the same time."

"Wait, what? It didn't follow you here, did it? I won't let anyone put my bar in danger."

"No. Wait. Maybe." Finn checked out the window. "No, nobody followed us."

"Good. I'll be going then." Double Trouble said, and made for the door.

"Hey, wait. We're gonna need to talk. I've got questions."

"...Fine. Don't really have any plans."

"Alright. Upstairs!" Finn pointed to a set of stairs, gesturing for the two shapeshifters to follow them. Melog and Double Trouble were close behind. They entered the room that had been provided, and Finn held the door for them, closing it firmly when they were inside. "Alright, Double Trouble. I want to know the truth. Why are

you helping me? Better question. Are you helping me at all, or is this all in your own best interests?"

"Kitten, everything I do is in my own best interests. It's how you survive in the world. Why are you asking me this? You didn't seem so picky about where your help came from before."

"That's because I wasn't. But *recent events* have caused me to become very suspicious about a lot of things. I mean, my *freaking cat* turned out to be- what the heck even are you anyway?" Melog shrugged. "Yeah, that clears things up a *whole lot.* Real helpful." Melog meowed sarcastically. "That is, if you're even the real Melog at all. What the heck happened to my cat?" Melog facepalmed. (facepawed?) Then shook its head. "Do you mean to tell me that you *are* my cat?" Melog made a 'more or less' gesture. "Nevermind, one subject at a time. Double Trouble. Explain."

"Hey, don't look at me! I mean, you remember what happened after Melog went all 'panther demon.' Catra said that it was working for her!" Melog temporarily took a humanoid shape in order to make a specific hand gesture at Double Trouble.

"That *is* what she said. Fuck, why can't anything be simple anymore."

"Finn, who the heck taught you that word?!" Double Trouble gasped. "You are a *child.* I may have done some morally dubious things in my day, but I *draw the line* at foul language."

"Aunt Sparkles. But as of right now, you're the *only one* around here who isn't working for Catra. You, me, and Huntara I guess, but she's already said she's not gonna do more than make sure I don't die of exposure or malnutrition. As messed up as it is, you're the only person I can trust on this quest." Double Trouble looked down. "But even then, it's still very suspicious! I just. Before this whole thing started, I was so excited. I was going to go out into the world and right a wrong. I was going to kill Catra, avenge my parents, and feel good. But right now, it just feels like something I want to be over and done with." Finn sighed. "I just want to go

home.” Double Trouble was strangely silent. They seemed to be thinking about something.

“What happens then?” They said hesitantly.

“Well, I’d clean myself off. The Crimson Wild is *filthy.* ” DT laughed at that. “After that, probably give my moms a big hug. I really miss them, you know? I haven’t seen them since I gave you my tech pad to disguise yourself as me, and you don’t seem to have it on you now, so… well, I’d hug them. Ask how thing’s have been since I left, apologize for the bait-and-switch I pulled, and making them worry about me and… OH! And I want to eat Cat’s cooking. I don’t know what’s in that grey stuff she makes, but it’s *delicious.* ”

“You really love your moms, dont you?” Double Trouble asked quietly.

“Of course I do. They’re the best moms a kid could ask for. I miss them.”

“...Then. Why not?”

“What?” Finn asked, looking at DT with confusion.

“Why not just. Go home? I mean, you were happy enough before all this, right? There’s no real reason to see it through, if it’s not what you want anymore.” Melog raised a curious and confused eyebrow at Double Trouble.

“I can’t. I already got Catra’s attention. I have to see this through now.”

“No. No you *don’t.* This is my fault, I gave you the stupid idea. It’s *me* they’ll be after, not you, okay? Catra’s not going to hurt you, and neither is Adora.”

“How do you know any of that? I tried to kill her, and I got pretty darn close. They chased me all the way out to the Crimson Wastes. Catra already says she wants to kill me herself!”

“That is not what she said, she said ‘the kid’s mine,’ there’s a difference.”

“What is the difference DT? What else could it possibly mean?”

“It means… it…” Double Trouble was quiet for a bit. “It was just her trying to stop the rest of the gang from killing you while still saving face,” They bluffed. “She has this reputation to protect, you know?”

“I can tell you’re making this up as you go.” Double Trouble sighed.

“Hell. I knew I should have taken that improv class. Well., I did, but it was all comedic stuff.”

“What the *hell* are you talking about?”

“ *Language,* kid.”

“Look, even if Catra were gonna just let me go, I have to do this. It’s not right to just let her get away with all this.”

“I’d be inclined to agree with you, except…” DT fidgeted. “Nevermind. I… don’t have anything to say that’ll change your mind,” They said looking down. “I… I gotta go.”

“No, you’re staying until-” Finn blinked. Double Trouble was gone, and the window was open. “Dangit.” Melog mad a disgruntled sound. “Fine then. Melog, I have no idea what you are or what’s going on. I don’t even know if I can trust you and you’re my childhood pet. But are you gonna help me, or what?” Melog hesitated for a moment, staring into Finn’s eyes, and nodded solemnly. “Glad to know where you stand, at least. Tonight, we sleep. Tomorrow, we kill Catra.”

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Finn had gotten home, but their moms weren't there. Instead, opening the door, was Catra herself, She-Ra behind her. Finn had attacked, but then-

They woke up. They needed to get this done, now.

"Melog. Catra's always been able to figure out where I am, and get there. I don't know how. I guess you have something to do with it." Melog nodded. "But you're gonna help me defeat her." Melog looked away, but nodded. "Then you lead her into a trap. Get her to leave She-Ra behind. I'll stow away on a cargo ship or something. No escape possible once it hits the water. No backup from She-Ra, and no help from you. It'll be an even fight, and I'll be able to find a nice hiding place to ambush her from." Melog nodded once. Then, it closed its eyes in concentration…

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Catra. Awaken.

Catra awakened. "Melog? What do you want?"

This has gone on long enough. I hate how it must end as much as you do, but the longer it is delayed, the more harm will come.

"How it must end? You mean me dying, right?"

Direct confrontation. But at this point, you're probably not wrong. It must be between you and them. Adora's interference would be… bad. In a fight like this.

"Melog, you know she wouldn't hurt Finn, right?"
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Not intentionally, but her powers are governed by instinct, not intent. Here is the ship, and how to get to it. Thoughts sprung to Catra's mind that had no way of getting there. Something that could be called a map, and a dingy boat that was obviously ex-Horde in design. *Be there soon.*

"Got it."

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Melog had made Finn invisible. Apparently that was a thing they could do. Good to know. The ship had drifted away from the harbor.

"Finn." Catra called from the deck. "I guess the fight starts now. But if it's okay, I want to talk a little bit first."

"You have *nothing* to say." Finn sprung from where they were waiting, illusion vanishing as Melog sprung to their side. Melog's mane and tail was still round and blue, but more of a sad blue than a calm blue.

"I have a lot to say, actually." Catra kept her hands in her pockets. Finn attacked with their claws. Catra sidestepped. "It doesn't really matter though. I hurt you and I'm sorry, but it doesn't matter, because that doesn't fix it."

"If you really felt so bad, you'd just stand *still* and let me finish this!" Finn yelled.

"...You know, you're probably right." Catra shrugged. Finn tackled her, knocking her over. They were close enough to see her eyes now. Blue and yellow, just like-

Catra slipped out of the hold easily.
~~~

"You know, when this is over, She Ra will probably leave you alone. She's not gonna avenge a vengeance, that just makes an infinite revenge loop. She always thought that was kinda dumb. So you're gonna be okay, okay?"

"Give up or fight back already! Don't keep dodging while you dictate your last will and testament."

"Kid, I *know* it's curtains for me. Doesn't mean I'm just gonna let it happen."

"Why not?"

"Holding out for some kind of miracle or something. I don't know." Finn went to sweep her leg. She blocked, and made as if to flip them, but simply set them down gently on their feet again. "Maybe you'll get too tired to keep fighting. Or maybe we'll have to fight someone else for some reason, or something else will happen that will make you stop wanting to kill me."

"Nothing will stop that."

"I figured as much." Finn dashed to knock Catra off the side of the ship, but Catra turned sideways. Then there they were, suspended in midair like Wile-E coyote before he remembers gravity exists. Or maybe that wasn't it, maybe time slowed down for them, and for Catra, and Melog at the same time.

They stopped falling sooner than they expected. They looked up. Catra had caught them by the hand. Finn wrestled to get their wrist free.

"Don't do that. Please." Catra said. "I did something very similar a long time ago. It's no good for you. Cat and Addie will miss you. You have friends and family you can count on. Don't forget that."

"You're right. If I die, I'll be missed." Finn seemed to relax for a moment. "But not *you."* Finn got their feet on solid ground again and pulled, taking Catra by surprise and knocking her off balance. They turned around and kicked her from behind, but they

miscalculated The force of the attack sent them both overboard, into the roaring water.

~~~

They say if you're running from dogs, you should cross running water because it will disrupt someone's scent. Anyone who's washed a fluffy animal will know that water only makes the smell stronger.

So at the same time as the spray Catra had used to disguise her smell was rinsed off, and the scarf she wore was carried away by the tide, it became incredibly clear to Finn exactly who they had been fighting earlier.

Catra grabbed Finn in one arm and started frantigally scrabbling for something to hold onto with the other. There was a bit of driftwood, so she climbed onto that.

The two drenched magicats stared at each other.

"...Mom?" Catra's eyes widened with panic. Melog appeared by her side, and then they both vanished.
~~~

In which it stops.

Chapter Summary

It's the end.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The tech pad rang. Adora scrambled for it.

“Hey Adora.” Catra said sadly.

“Catra? Catra! Are you okay? What happened? I woke up and you were gone and-”

“...They know.” Adora gasped softly. “... It’s over, isn’t it?”

“What do you mean, ‘it’s over?’ What’s over?” Catra didn’t say anything. “Answer me, Catra! What’s over? What happened, or what’s going to happen-”

“Everything. Nothing. I don’t know. It just felt- I don’t know. Accurate?”

“I know that feeling. It’s how I felt when-” when Catra dropped her off the cliff in the Crystal Castle, when Catra activated the portal, when Catra saved Glimmer at the cost of her own life, when Catra was forced to throw herself of the precepice on Horde Prime’s ship, when- “...When I thought my world had come to an end.”

“The end of the world all over again.” Catra said, echoing what she’d said to Melog so long ago. Or was it only a little while? “...I guess you should call Finn. Get Glimmer to pick them up, to go wherever they want to go. Whether they want to just go home, keep hunting me, or get as far away from me as they can, that’s up to them I guess. We should get going too, I guess.”

"...I guess. Why don't you call Finn?"

"You know why! …Sorry for yelling, I shouldn't have done that. I shouldn't have done a lot of things. But I can't look Finn in the eyes right now. Not when I know they'd be looking back at me, and actually *seeing* me. It's scary."

"...I'll call them. See you soon."

"Yeah. Real soon."

~~~

Melog had reappeared to guide Finn back to shore. They were drenched but otherwise none the worse for wear.

"Hey, Melog. I guess that really *is* you, huh?" Melog nodded. "Thanks for saving me, but please go away. I- I just need to be alone right now. Melog nodded again and disappeared.

Hell. This was all weird. Cat was *Catra.* Or was it the other way around? What was more shocking, finding out that your mother was the tyrant who led the Red Horde to conquer Salineas, or finding out that the tyrant who led the Red Horde to conquer Salineas was *your mother?* That meant that Addie was Adora, didn't it? Finn's parents were *Force Captain Catra* and *She-Ra, Princess of Power.* And they had lied to Finn for as long as they'd all known each other.

Or had they? There was that one thing that Cat- *Catra* had kept trying to tell them. She'd wanted them to know something, but kept losing her nerve. Was that the secret she'd kept trying to tell them?

The kid is mine.
~~~

What would you do if Catra were someone you knew? Someone you cared about?

You really love your moms, don't you?

It made a lot of sense in hindsight.

One revelation led to another. Sparkles and King weren't leading Finn to their death, they were trying to work with their mom to look after them. Addie was the one most strongly opposed to Finn's quest to Catra- of course she was! Catra was her *wife!* Catra was Finn's mother.

Double Trouble's tragedy. The one where a kid goes out to kill his mother. Was that what this was? But they'd changed their mind at the end. Why didn't they change their mind sooner, or tell Finn the truth?

Why didn't *anybody?*

As it was, Cat would rather Finn *kill her* then know the truth ,but they'd learn eventually. Whether they unmasked her body or went home only to discover that nobody was waiting for them with warm smiles or soft fluffy hugs. Maybe Addie would forgive them, tell them everything would be alright, that despite everything she was still their mother and she loved them more than anything. Or maybe she wouldn't. Maybe Finn would just be alone again.

And Finn? What would Finn do if they'd known sooner? They didn't know. They didn't even know what they were supposed to do *now.* Go through with it, or let it be?

The tech pad rang. Finn picked up.

"Hey! Finn! I, uh, heard that you learned about Cat! Being Catra! And, um…" Addie- no, *She-Ra* sighed. "Sorry. About everything. The lying was my idea. I didn't want to have to be She-Ra forever. Cat wanted to tell you the truth, until-"

"Until she got worried about how I'd react." Finn accused

“I- I guess. I- Do you- I mean, are you okay with- I mean, you know where Catra lives now! So… do you wanna go there?”

“Joking? Now? Really? …Yeah. I wanna go home.”

“I’ll call Glimmer to pick you up. I mean, aunt Sparkles! I mean, surprise, your aunt Sparkles is the queen of Brightmoon! She’s going to teleport you home now. Oh! Surprise! She can teleport! Heh… heh.” Addie- No, *She-Ra* looked stressed and scared and nervous and *terrified.* The expression she was wearing could possibly be called a smile, but it looked more like the lifeless corpse of a smile that was raised in unholy undeath by unethical science or dark magic.

“I guess that makes sense, doesn’t it? Better than sailing a ship or flying a horse. …I guess this is all over.”

“You know, Cat said something similar just now.”

“...Whatever. See you soon.” Finn moved to press the ‘hang up’ button.

“Wait.” Finn stopped. Adora’s simulacrum of a smile had crumbled like autumn leaves under someone’s foot. She sounded panicked and just a little breathless. “When you get home. When you see Cat again… what are you going to do?” Finn hung up. The tech pad rung again. They didn’t answer.

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Glimmer appeared next to Finn in a burst of glitter. “Hey. You look like a wreck.”

“Feel like a wreck.”
~~~

"...You know, I tried to kill Catra once. I was doing something else important, but I figured I might as well take her out as long as I was in the right place. I'd gotten one of her old friends to lead me into the Horde base she was in at the time. She made me promise not to kill her once I found her. I was lying, obviously, but… anyway, I showed up where she was, and I was all like 'are you ready to die?' and she was all like 'well as a matter of fact, I am.' and then Horde Prime kidnapped us, she pledged allegiance to him, backstabbed him, and we've been besties ever since."

"Just take me home. Then go."

"...Okay." A swarm of pink stars carried Finn and Glimmer to the the path of stepping stones that led home. Glimmer vanished immediately after, as Finn had requested. They stood there for a moment. Then another moment. And another. And another, and another, and another…

After all these moments had passed, Finn moved. They walked towards the door, every footstep feeling like an odyssey of its own that made the journey before it seem inconsequential and brief. They grabbed the doorknob as though they thought it was booby-trapped, wired to burn their hand or electrocute them. It felt cool to the touch. They opened the door. There was the living room, with the couch and the chairs and the coffee table and the footrest and the fireplace and the large tech pad mounted on the wall for movie nights and the kitchen right next to it because Cat and Addie both thought it was stupid to have an entire room devoted to eating when the living room had a table and so much, and there was the refrigerator where the crayon art Finn had made years ago was hung up proudly with magnets and there was the mantlepiece covered in more photos than it could fit and there was this and that and so many other things than Finn could focus on at once.

And there was Addie and Melog. Addie looked like she'd been crying. Melog was purring, but it seemed to be mostly for Adora's sake. But someone was missing.

“Mom? Where’s Catra?”

“Oh. She’s… she’s not here right now. Hey, you had a long journey. Do you want to relax for a bit and-”

“Where is she?” Adora seemed to realize that she couldn’t avoid this.

“She went to that bar we caught you trying to sneak into last year.”

“The Busted Blade Burgers and Beer, I remember it well. For the record, I wasn’t going to drink anything, I’d just wanted to try the salmon burgers. They were really good burgers, by the way.”

“Uh-huh.” The two of them laughed hollowly.

“... Well, I guess I’ll get going then.”

“... I guess you will. See you soon.”

“You aren’t going to try to stop me?”

“I already tried,” She said sadly. Her voice cracked a little.

“I meant, like, fight me.”

“No. Never.”

“...Huh.”

“...I thought about it. But every time I imagined it, it just… hurt. I couldn’t.”

“Huh. Thanks, I guess. But, that aside, I need to find Catra.”

“I guess you do, huh? See you soon.” Addie smiled sadly. Finn turned around and walked back out the door, looking back once before shutting it. Through the door, they could hear her start crying again. They felt sick.

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"Hey, bartender, what's in this stuff?"

"Milk, mostly. It's just fermented milk."

"Huh. This whole time, I thought that's how you made cheese. I guess it's also how you make alcohol."

"Different kind of fermented. Different kind of milk, too. This is Kumis, which is horse milk." Cat started laughing.

"Oh holy sweet mara on a stick, Swiftwind would get a kick out of *that!* Let me tell you. This guy. He thinks that *allllll* horses are people. And they all deserve chairs to sit on. Like, wouldn't they break the chairs? I mean, there's only *one* horses that I know about that can actually do that peopleing stuff, and that's *shitwhinnie* or whatever the fuch his name is I forgot. Wait. Not fuch. Funck. FUCK. There! I got it! First try, fuck yeah!"

"Cat, I've never seen you drink this much. I've never seen you drink *at all* , and you're my only regular."

"That's because your milkshakes taste good and your alcohol doesn't, but nobody in their right minds goes to a bar for milkshake. Anyway. Your point?"

"My point is, what gives? What happened?"

"Oh. OH! I got it. So I'm Catra, by the way. And I've been living under a secret idennidy becuzz *Adora* wants to live a normal cute life like she didn't save the world and I didn't try to end it. It'sssss cute. She'ss cute. I love her. But then Finn found out that *Catra* killed their parents so they wanna kill her. BHut then they found out that *I'm* Catra so now they wanna kill me and that'll scar thenm for life so I'm gonna go out with alcohol poisoning so they
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don’t have to get my blood on their hands. Or lactose intolerance poisoning, whichever works first.”

“Well, you’ve officially had *way* too much already. No more alcohol for you.” The bartender suddenly realized something. “Wait, you’re lactose intolerant? Then why the heck do you order milkshakes all the time?”

“Well, when you shake the milk all the lactose falls out.” She said, like someone explaining the alphabet to a toddler.

“No it doesn’t!”

“It doesn’t?” Catra asked, confused. “Mermista, you waterborne piece of *shit* you *lied* to me!” She shouted at nobody who was there. “Explains the stomachaches I have so often. This whole time I thought it was guilt. I guess it was just the milk. Fuckit. ANOTHER!”

“Ma’am, you’ve drunk so much you think you’re Catra. I think it’s time you had some water.”

“Noooo, I hate water. Everytime I go on a boat I wind up in the water. Sure it was only two times, but it’s a one to one correlation. I go on the boat, I get in a fight, I go in the water. It’s *synchronicity.”*

“You can pronounce sink- sinkro- whatever the hell, but you can’t pronounce *fuck?”*

“Swear Jar.”

“What???” the door swung open.

“FINN! Hi, I was just talking about how you wanted to kill me!”

“Hey, you here to take her home? I accidentally gave her too much, now she’s getting delirious.”

"...I guess I am." Finn turned their attention to their mother. "Hi, Catra."

"...So she was telling the truth?" The bartender asked.

"Yeah. Well, probably. Don't know everything she said to you. You know, when I first decided to kill Catra, I thought it should be quick. Don't let her try to excuse or explain or justify anything, just attack when I could and-" Finn snapped their fingers. "But now that I know who she is, I just want to know *why.* And now she's in no state to tell me anything at all."

"Hey, I *am* in a state!"

"Yes. Yes you are." The bartender quipped.

"...I could use a moment alone with her."

"Are you really gonna-" Finn gave the bartender a look. "...I'l leave you to it, then." They walked away, leaving Finn and Catra there on the bar. Catra looked at the empty glass on the table as though it was full of her hopes and dreams. Then she knocked it off of the edge with one sweep of her hand. It klonked onto the floor.

"So, you gonna kill me or what?" she asked, with the same tone of voice as if she was asking them whether they were going to finish their supper before it got cold.

"I want to talk to you a little bit. If that's okay."

"Alright. I'm not in a rush. The opposite of that, actually. Talk away, and I'll talk back! I mean, I won't *talk back,* but I'll talk as well."

"...Why did you do what you did?"

"I've "did" a lot of "whats." Finn. You're gonna have to be more specific."

“Alright. Why did you conquer Salineas?”

“Because if you control Salineas, you control the oceans, and if you control the oceans, you control the world.”

“Why conquer anyone at all?”

“Because I was in the Horde, and the Horde’s whole point is conquering. And I think I already told you why I was in the Horde, and why I left it, and all that other stuff. You just didn’t know I was Catra back then.” Catra paused. “This reminds me of Shadow Weaver.”

“She’s the one who raised you and Adora, right?”

“Razed is more like it. But those two words sound the same. Razed, raised, razzle dazzle. Where was I? Oh right! She was horrible. She hurt me, and she hurt Adora, and I had the opportunity to get back at her. Then she was all like ‘Catra I’ve always loved you and cared about you and that’s why I constantly zapped the bajeezus out of you, I only wanted to make you strong’ and you know the stupid thing? I funkin -FUCKING- believed her. Then she asked me for a favor and I did that favor and then she got out and she came back later just to zap the bajeezus out of me again. That’s why I decided to destroy the world. Which is just STUPID. *One* crazy lady who hurt me says she always loved me and I fucking believed her, and when it turns out she tricked me I decide to kill literally everybody at once with the portal.”

“Why are you telling me all this?”

“You wanted to talk.”

“Alright, that’s fair. Why are you thinking about Shadow Weaver?”

“Because I remember her saying something to me a long time ago. Something that turned out to be right. She said that I reminded her of herself. That I was like her. And I am.”

"What? But you're nothing like-"

"A while ago you said I was nothing like *Catra.* Who I *am.* So trust me to know who I'm like. Even if you don't trust me for anything else. Which you *shouldn't.* Because I'll just take your trust and use it to make a teleportation symbol on the ground and teleport away leaving you with a boss who says 'breathing is a privilege, not a right' and then proves it."

"What?"

"You wouldn't get the reference, it's an inside joke. Or an inside choke, heh. But let me count the ways I'm like Shadow Weaver: Way number one, electric floor thingy. I used tech based on her magic against Adora. I wasn't even trying to kill her, she was already trapped, I just wanted her to suffer because I was mad at her. Way number two, I killed your parents and then I became your parents, and I made you love me. Adora says that isn't what happened. I don't agree with her, but if I told her that it'd make her sad. Way number three, I lied to you for your whole life. Way number four, all of *this.* " She gestured to herself. "When Shadow Weaver died, it was a heroic self sacrifice thing. She went and blew herself up. She was drunk at the time, just like I am now. And do you know what she said? *You're welcome.* Well guess what, Finn? You're *not* welcome! I am a bad person and I hurt you and I hurt so many other people and I took your family away and I did it all for no good reason, and you owe me *nothing* except maybe a bullet between the eyes or a claw through my throat, and I'm sorry I did that, I'm sorry I conquered your kingdom, I'm sorry I lied about it, I'm sorry I fought you on that stupid ship, and I'm sorry I dissappeared after that, and I'm sorry I drank too much to give you the talk you want and I'm sorry for every single bad thing that ever I ever did that I can't remember because I'm too damn drunk right now." She paused to breathe. "At least there's *one* thing I don't have in common with her."

"Mom, I…" Finn couldn't finish.

"You still wanna talk, or… is the conversation over?"

“I guess it kind of is, isn’t it?”

“So kid, what happens now?” Catra asked.

~~~

All those years ago, Salineas was empty. Everyone there had been killed by the Horde or evecuated by the Rebellion, and Catra was in the middle of it all. She was giving some directions to Force Captain Dumb Face (Octavia) to go look for survivors in order to make sure that they didn’t survive for any longer.

Work was hard and stressful, and now that Scorpia was gone, there was nobody around here she trusted. Not that she had ever trusted Scorpia, she’d always known that despite her friendliness and alleged total loyalty, she would betray her eventually like everyone else had.

And she’d turned out to be right, hadn’t she? Scorpia had left her to join the Rebellion and save Entrapta, yet another traitor who’d thought she’d earned Catra’s trust. But Catra had only ever trusted one person in her life. Maybe two. And look how that turned out?

Still stung. She expected to be betrayed, it was inevitable. The only reason to put one’s arms around someone was to find the right spot on their back to stick a knife into when the time comes. But it still hurt. At least she could trust Double Trouble. They weren’t working for her because of something as flimsy as love or loyalty, they were doing it in their own self interest. And that’s something that she could count on. But Double Trouble was busy doing some backstabbing for Catra, and so Catra was all alone. Except for the troops she had to command.

Fuck it. This is exhausting. Catra started delegating duties to the other Force Captains. As Second in Command, she had all the
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power. Lord Hordak was eating out of the palm of her hand, and the rest of the Horde was cleaning her litterbox. And what's the point of unchecked power if you don't use it to get a little bit of a break from everything now and then?

Duties split between her underlings, Catra sighed with relief. Finally, she could just relax and enjoy the sweet (sickening) sensation of victory. No jobs to do, nobody to fight, nobody to yell at her for doing nothing because there was nobody with the authority to do so. Perfectly calm and peaceful.

Until the baby started crying. Catra groaned. Of *course* there would be a baby right here. Of *course* the recruiters would manage to lose one of those infernal noise machines *right where* Catra had decided to take her break. And of *course* it wouldn't be dead yet. Just Catra's luck.

She followed the sound of the whining to a house that was small, but not *too* small for a family.

Catra wondered who lived there. She wondered if the inhabitants had evacuated or been killed. There were always some familes who survived but got separated, and there were always orphans. All made good cadets for the Horde.

This baby, though, was just irritating. Disturbing Catra's break. She needed to shut it up, *now.*

She walked through the busted down door. She passed the furnishings which marked this place as having been inhabited once, and walked up the stairs. There, at the top, was a hallway with several doors. She only cared about one. The one where the crying was coming from. She opened the door slowly.

There, in front of her, was a cradle. The ceiling just to the right of it had collapsed from a laser blast. If Hordak had aimed just a little bit to the other side, this kid would just be dead, and Catra could have gone about her day as planned. This *thing* needed to be *taken care of.*

Problem is, Catra does not know how to take care of babies.

"What do you want kid?" she asked, picking it up. "Is it milk? Because I don't have any." Baby kept crying. "You know this would be a lot easier if you talked." Baby cried louder. "You… do know how to talk, right?" Incoherent angry babbling. "Go figure. My day's ruined by a baby who can't even talk. Unless babies *usually* can't talk? I don't know, maybe they covered that in Force Captain orientation." Hm. What would Scorpia do in a situation like this? "Shhh. Let all your cares go…" Said Catra, trying to fold the blanket around the squirming child. "Would you hold still? I'm *trying* to comfort you!" The baby made a scream that sounded suspiciously like a sonic weapon the Horde was testing out. "Ah jeez. And the call *me* a tyrant." She looked around for something she could use to make this thing chill out. There was a name carved into the cradle. "Okay, *Finn,* let me try something else." The baby was instantly silenced, looking at Catra with intense curiosity. "That's your name, isn't it? Finn? It's carved into your weird bed-cage thing." The baby wasn't crying anymore, but they started making some weird baby noises.

Catra decided it was time to put this thing to sleep.

So she started to sing. Well, it wasn't singing, really. There were no words. No real tune, either. Just some half remembered bits of overheard songs that got stuck together in her brain. Weirdly enough, it seemed to work, and young Finn was lulled into a deep sleep.

"Goodnight, Finn. Sleep well. I'll call the recruiters in the morning, yell at them because they missed a spot. Until then, don't die." Finn made a noise in their sleep, but Catra decided that was okay. It was kind of cute, even. She spent the rest of her self-made break standing over the cradle, watching the young kitten snore to make sure it didn't just stop breathing for some reason.

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Cat and Addie looked through the swarm of children.

"So, 'Cat,' meet anyone you like?"

"Yeah, but I know you were looking for a baby. So I don't think-" Over on the other side of the playground, the cat kid she'd met earlier spotted her and dashed over.

"Hi miss Cat! It's me again. I just wanted to say hi because you were so nice, and also because I forgot to tell you my name!"

"Oh? What is it?" Cat asked, looking at the smaller magicat.

"I'm Finn!" Cat immediately looked at Addie.

"This one's mine. We're keeping them." Addie smiled at her wife.

"Of course we are."

The three of them went home together that day, and they were all happy.

Chapter End Notes

What a ride, folks! Hope you enjoyed. Does Finn kill Catra? Hell if I know. Let me know if I missed a tag, okay? Thanks!

The Dragon

Chapter Summary

DT has a meeting with 'The Dragon.'

"Double Trouble. Is it done?" The Dragon asked.

"No. I... couldn't do it. I'll be returning your down payment, naturally." DT responded.

"I could pay you more. I need you to see this through.:

"Listen, even though we're both lizards, even *I'm* not cold blooded enough to do this anymore. Catra might still die at this point, but I want nothing else to do with any of this."

"I can't tell if you grew a backbone or lost it. Did you finally go soft and start caring about one of your marks, or did you get scared of an old retired war veteran?"

"Our business is concluded. Go find someone else to get Finn to do your dirty work."

"Wait, you got *Finn* to kill Catra?"

"I tried. I don't know if I succeeded." DT admitted.

"Oh, that's just delicious. You truly are an artist, Double Trouble. Keep the down payment. Even if it didn't work, you earned it. I have much more in my hoard, I don't need it anyway."

"Stop it with the dragon shit already. I know you're not a real dragon, you're just a-"

"I know what I am, thank you very much. But a lizard like me can dream, can't I? Sometimes, it's all I can do." The 'Dragon' flapped its tiny feathery wings and flew away, leaving a handful of data disks on the ground in front of Double Trouble.

"Wow, what a drama queen." Double Trouble picked up the bits of First One's tech from the ground and retreated into the forest.

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